

# Status of DTS Validation in Linux Kernel

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  - I co-maintain also the soc subsystem (arm-soc)
  - ... and a few Linux kernel subsystems and drivers
- I contributed a lot to the Linux kernel, although now I mostly read the code
  - `git shortlog -s -n --no-merges | head -n 5`

# Agenda

- What is the DTS validation?
- Why does it matter (how many issues can this find?)
- The results!
  - Architectures
  - SoC Platforms

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- These opinions are my own and do not reflect the views of my employer

# What Is the DTS Validation?





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- Devicetree bindings - set of rules how DTS should be constructed and documenting the ABI between software and DTS
- Devicetree schema (DT Schema) is the current format of Devicetree bindings
  - ... and the toolset
  - ... and a project: <https://github.com/devicetree-org/dt-schema/>

# What Is the DTS Validation?

- Devicetree bindings, in the DT Schema format, can be used to check if the DTS (sources) comply:
  - All required properties present
  - No undocumented ABI
  - All compatibles documented in the DT Schema format (not TXT!)
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  - All required properties present
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  - All compatibles documented in the DT Schema format (not TXT!)
  - Property values within constraints
- Compliance here means: no warnings from ``make dtbs_check``

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arch/arm64/boot/dts/qcom/Makefile:  
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- Whenever mentioning here a “target”, it means DTB file, being created by the Makefile
  - Basically a ``grep -E '(DTC|OVL).*\.dtb$'`` on the output of ``make dtbs_check``

# Why Does It Matter?



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Whack-a-Mole with DTS Validation in the Linux Kernel  
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- Evaluated Linux kernel commits for DTS if two SoC vendors:
  - Samsung Exynos, between Linux kernel v5.3 and v6.8
  - Qualcomm, between Linux kernel v5.18 and v6.8

# Glossary (Still 2024 Recap)

- “Commit for DTS” means:
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- “Commit for DTS” means:
  - Touching arch/FOO/boot/dts/BAR/ files
- Commit being a result of DTS validation means:
  - Commit to fix explicit warning from DTS validation (``make dtbs_check``)
  - Usually clearly noted in the commit message
    - At least when people wrote good commit messages, explaining why they are doing something
      - ... not what they are doing :(

# Recap 2024 - Commits from the DTS Validation

- Of all commits touching DTS files in Linux kernel:
  - Samsung Exynos: 30-40% of commits were result of DTS validation
  - Qualcomm: 20-30% of commits were result of DTS validation

# Results (Recap 2024)

This and several other slides are directly imported from my 2024 talk: <https://sched.co/1aBEf>

| Platform                     | Total DTS commits | Commits as a result of DT schema validation | %   |
|------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----|
| ARM Exynos v5.3 .. v6.8      | 370               | 152                                         | 41% |
| ARM64 Exynos v5.3 .. v6.8    | 139               | 46                                          | 33% |
| ARM Qualcomm v5.18 .. v6.8   | 476               | 142                                         | 30% |
| ARM64 Qualcomm v5.18 .. v6.8 | 2512              | 545                                         | 22% |

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    - If only people could answer “why” they are doing what they are doing...
- See my slides from 2024 for the reasoning behind classification and examples

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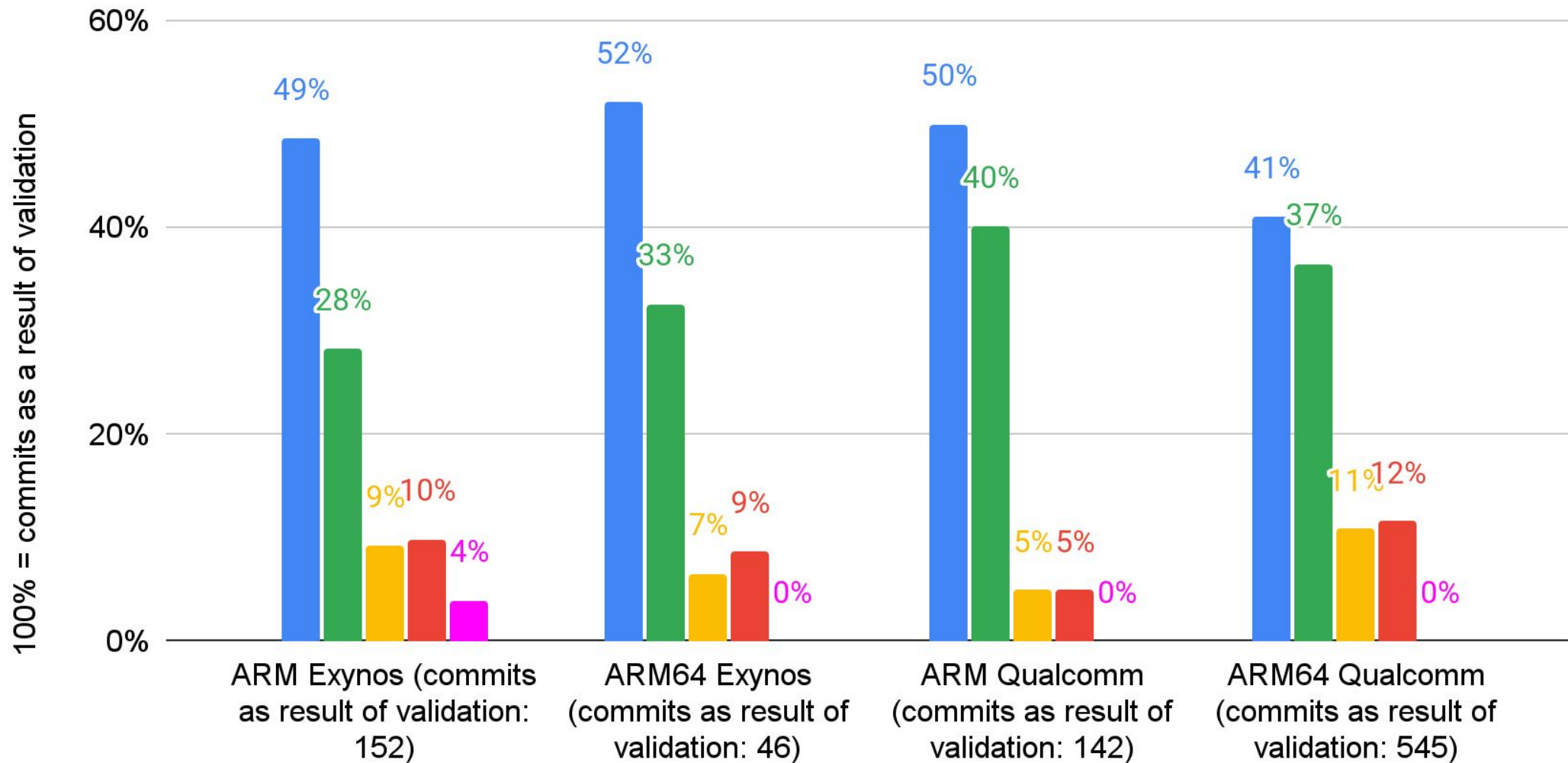
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  - **POSSIBLE FIX**
- Something does not work
  - **REAL FIX**
- Something does not work, but DT schema did not detect it yet
  - **FUTURE FIX**

## Classification of Commits as Result of Validation

■ Style ■ Improvement ■ Possible fix ■ Real fix ■ Future fix



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- Because it points out real bugs in DTS (~10% of the cases)
- And makes DTS better in the rest of the cases
- If better code did not convince you then:

**It is a requirement for Arm SystemReady Devicetree band**



# Status of Architectures



# Kernel Versions

- All further slides show results as of Linux kernel:
  - Future v6.19 (next-20251125) - not for all slides
    - Validated with dtschema v2025.08
  - Latest v6.18, released few days ago
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  - v6.13, released January 2025
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  - v6.7, released January 2024
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- Trying to show change happening during last year
- Comparing with earlier Linux kernel releases is tricky, because dtschema is stricter now
  - Therefore trying to use dtschema package from that era

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  - Several other (ARC, Microblaze, NIOS2) are basically legacy and no work is done
  - No point to measure legacy
- Some architecture or SoC platforms have both ACPI and Devicetree, but only ACPI is being actively developed
  - Lack of activity in DTS does not necessarily mean stuff is definitely abandoned!

# Architectures Tested Here

- ARM
  - ``ls arch/arm/boot/dts``
  - Everything which could build, so includes ARMv7, ARMv6 and ancient ARMv4T (ARM9 like TI Nspire calculator)
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- RISC-V
- Loongarch
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- RISC-V
- Loongarch
- PowerPC
- Not included in my talk
  - MIPS - allyesconfig builds only part of it (being fixed by Rob)
  - Pity if some architectures wanted to be on this list, but ``git log`` does not lie

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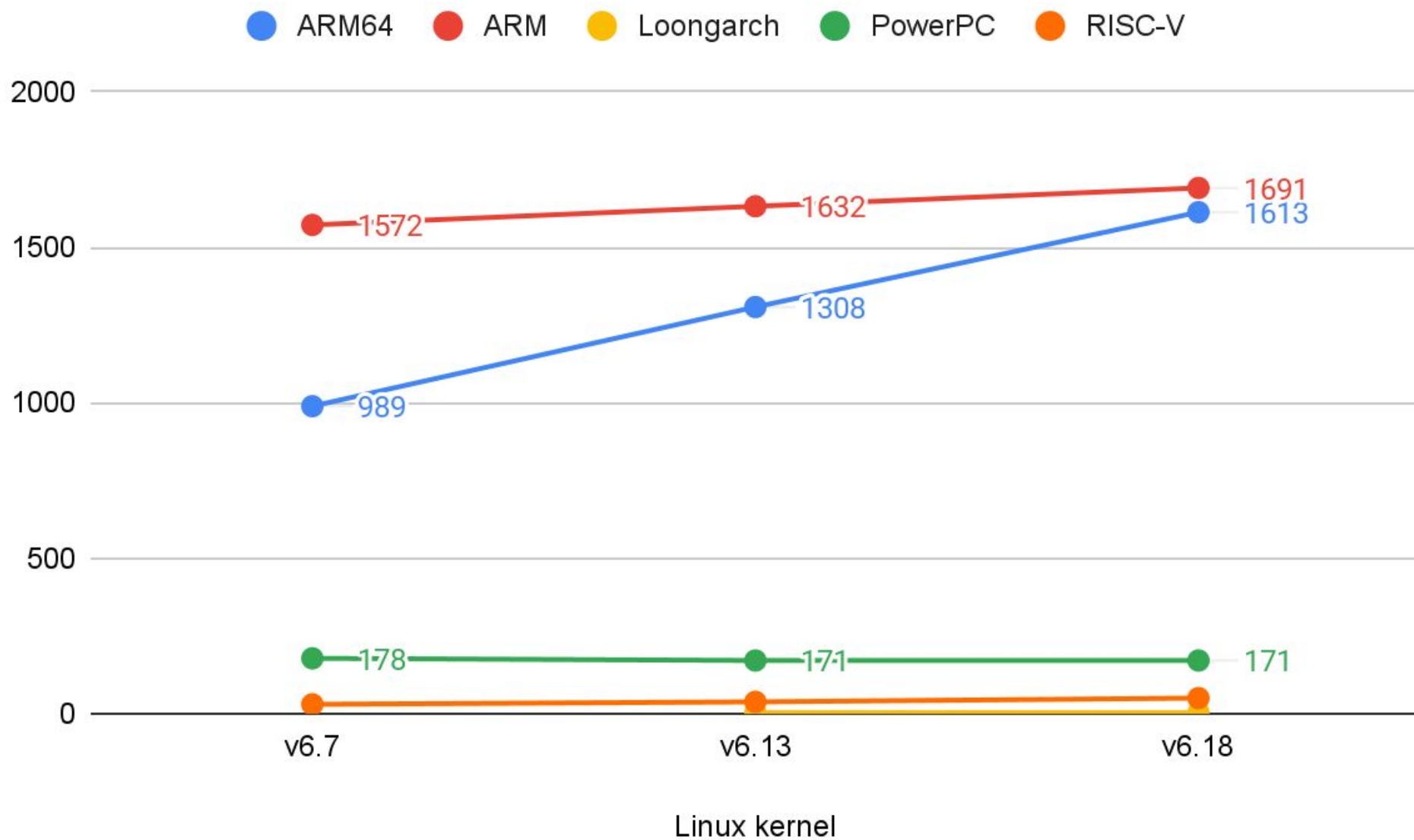
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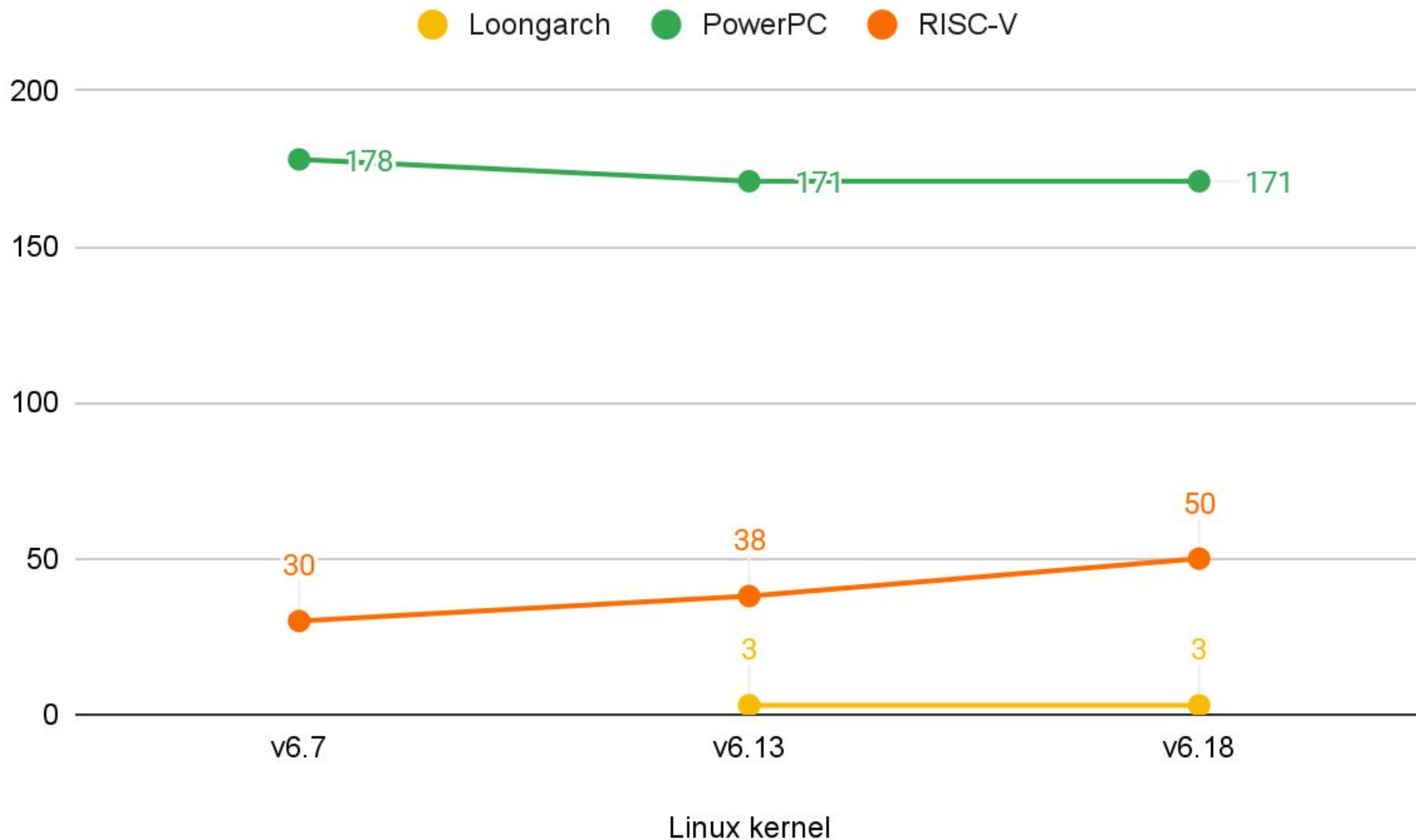
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- Same issue in a DTSI file, included by multiple DTS, will result in multiple warnings
  - To offset this, more interesting metrics are:
    - number of warnings / number of targets
    - number of warnings / number of Lines of Code (kLoC)

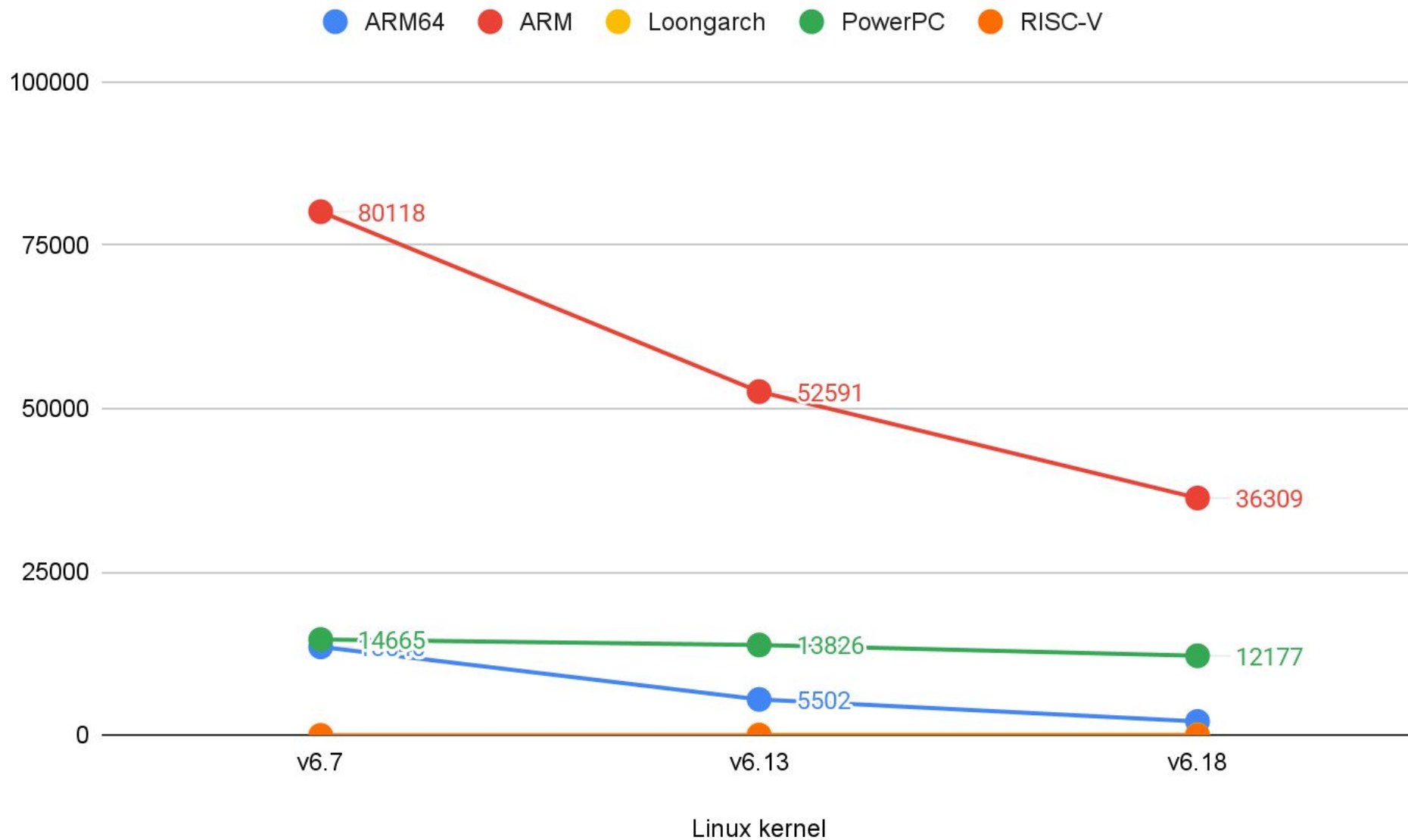
# Targets per Architecture



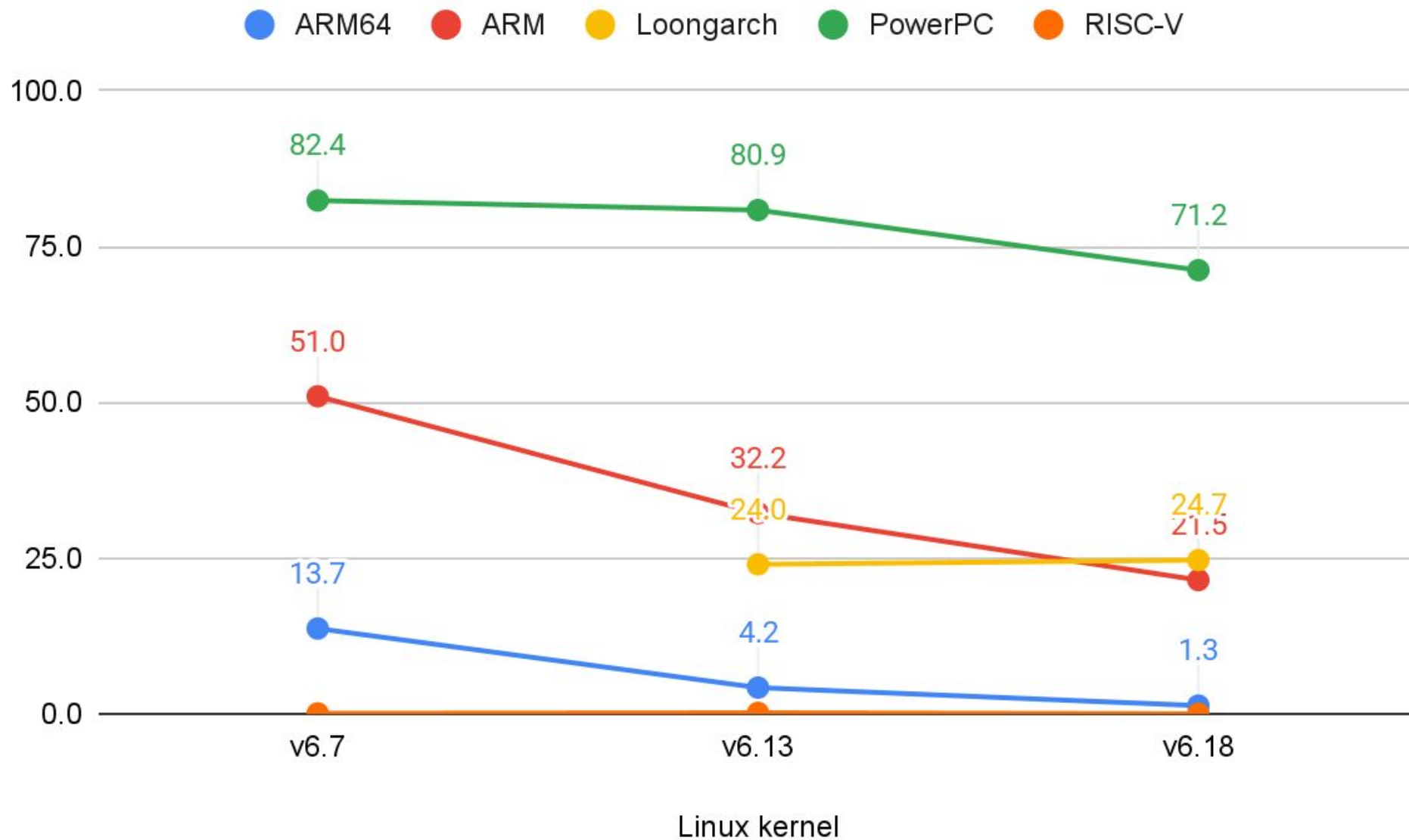
# Targets per Architecture (Loongarch, PowerPC and RISC-V)



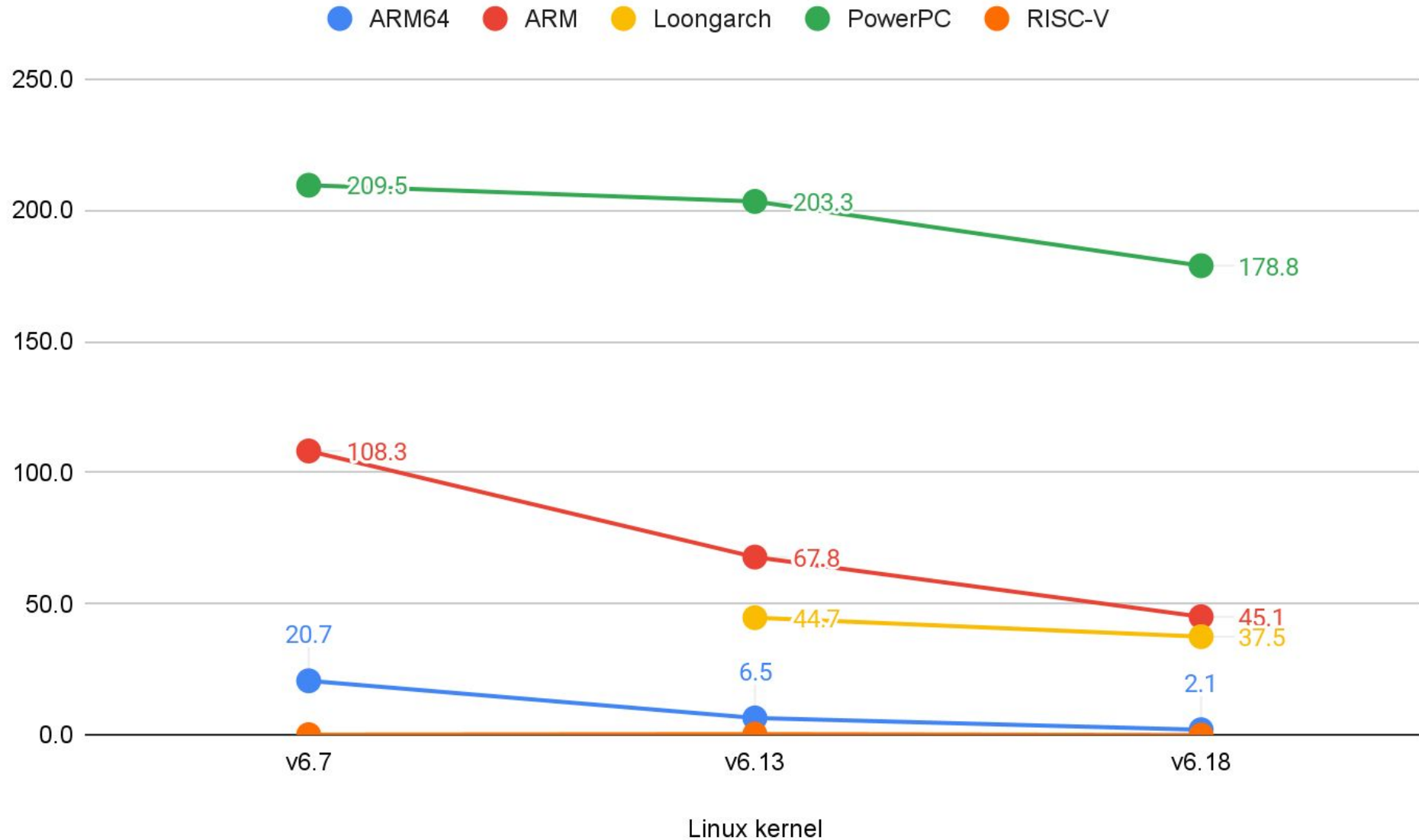
# Total DTBs Check Warnings (Lower Better)



# DTBs Check Warnings / Target (Lower Better)



# DTBs Check Warnings / 1000-Lines-of-Code (Lower Better)



# DTBs Check Warnings / Target (Lower Better)

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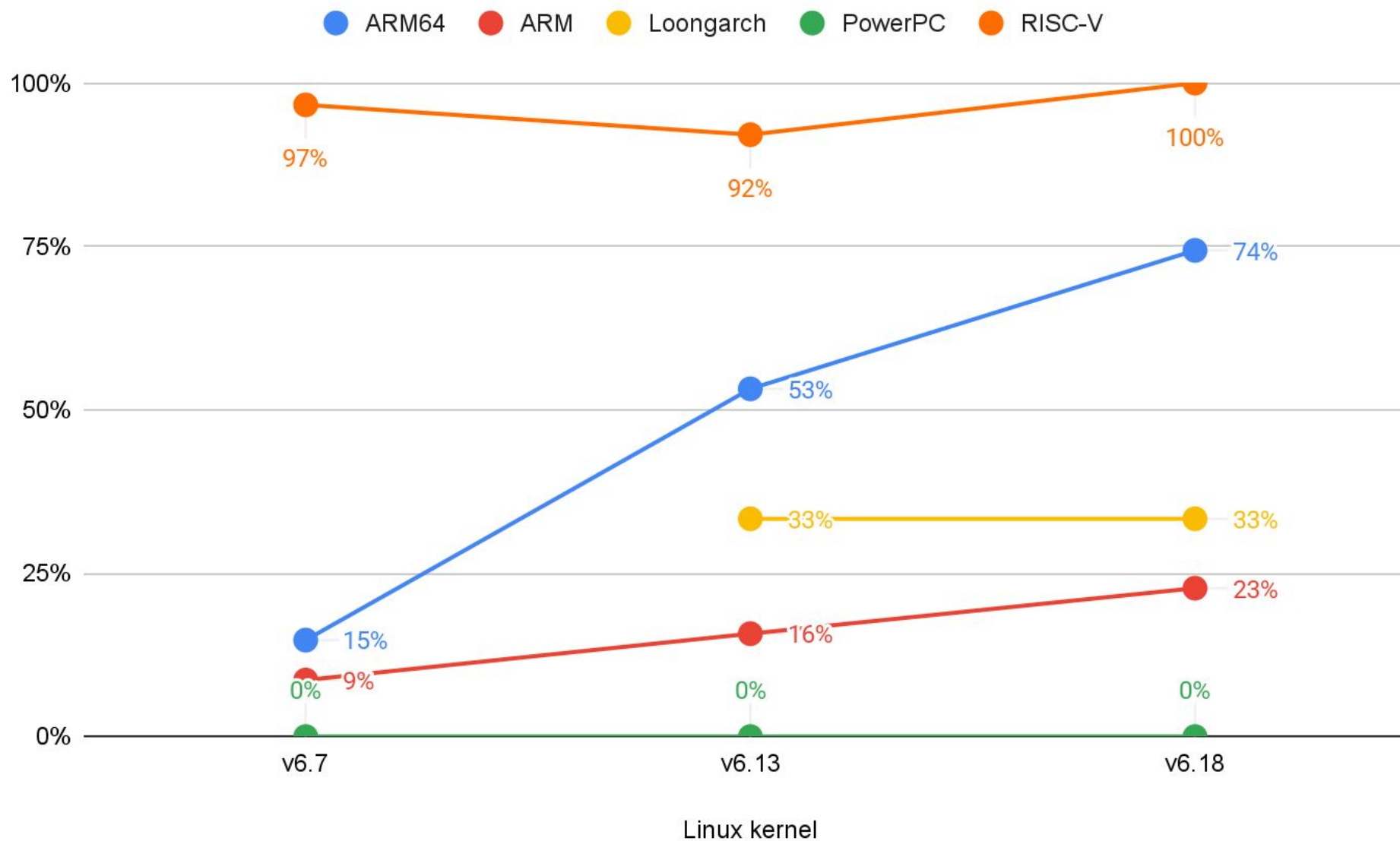
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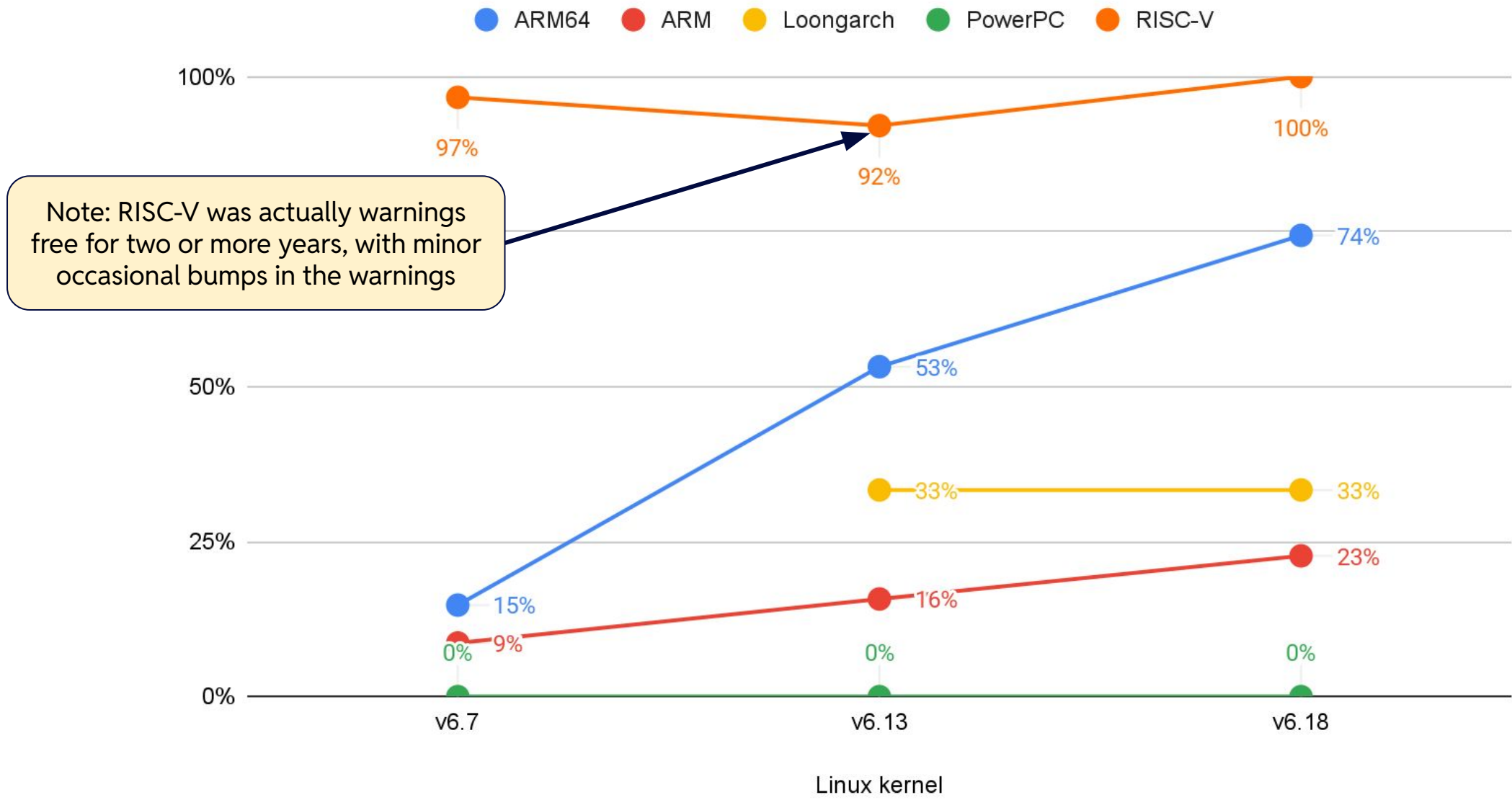
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- Conclusion: the size of your ecosystem does not guarantee your DTS will be correct
  - Thank you, Captain Obvious!

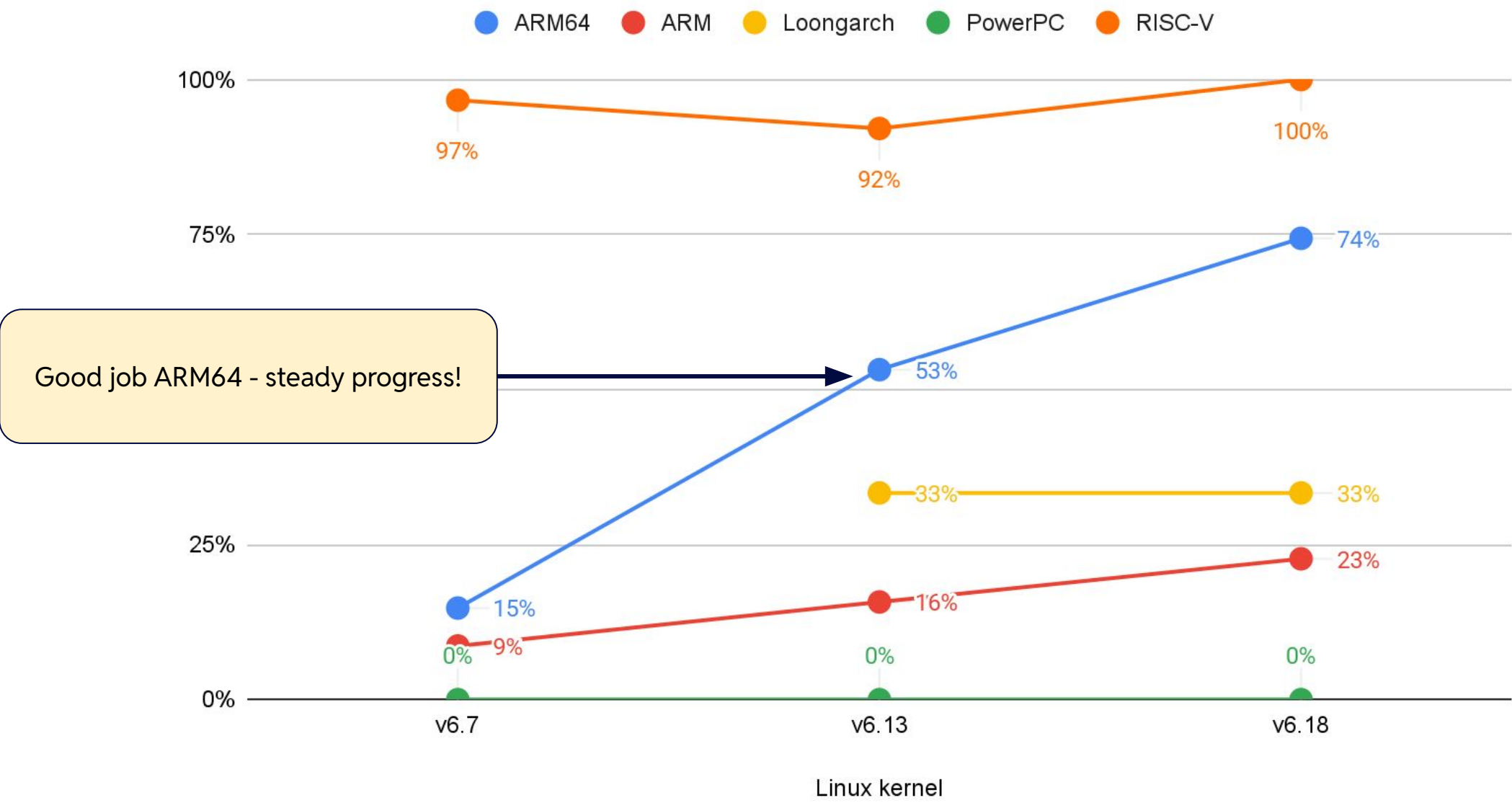
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    - Only 1 out 3 DTBs clean of warnings...
- Old architectures with “stable” boards just don’t get fixes?
- The biggest architecture in the kernel - ARM64 - can get fixed as well!

# Status of (SoCs) Platforms



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    - `arch/riscv/boot/dts/microchip/`
  - But there are exceptions...
- Sometimes very different SoC families within, e.g. Freescale LS and NXP i.MX
  - Five subdirectories in `arch/arm/boot/dts/nxp/`



# SoC Platforms Being Actively Improved

- Sometimes big difference in the activity and size:
  - `git log --no-merges --oneline v6.7..v6.18 -- arch/arm64/boot/dts/qcom/ | wc -l`
    - 1982
  - `git ls-files arch/arm64/boot/dts/qcom/ | wc -l`
    - 516
  - `git log --no-merges --oneline v6.7..v6.18 -- arch/arm64/boot/dts/intel/ | wc -l`
    - 22
  - `git ls-files arch/arm64/boot/dts/intel/ | wc -l`
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  - To offset this, more interesting metrics are:
    - number of warnings / number of targets
    - number of warnings / number of Lines of Code (kLoC)

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## SoC Platforms - PowerPC

- PowerPC has no per-vendor split, thus not investigating individual platforms



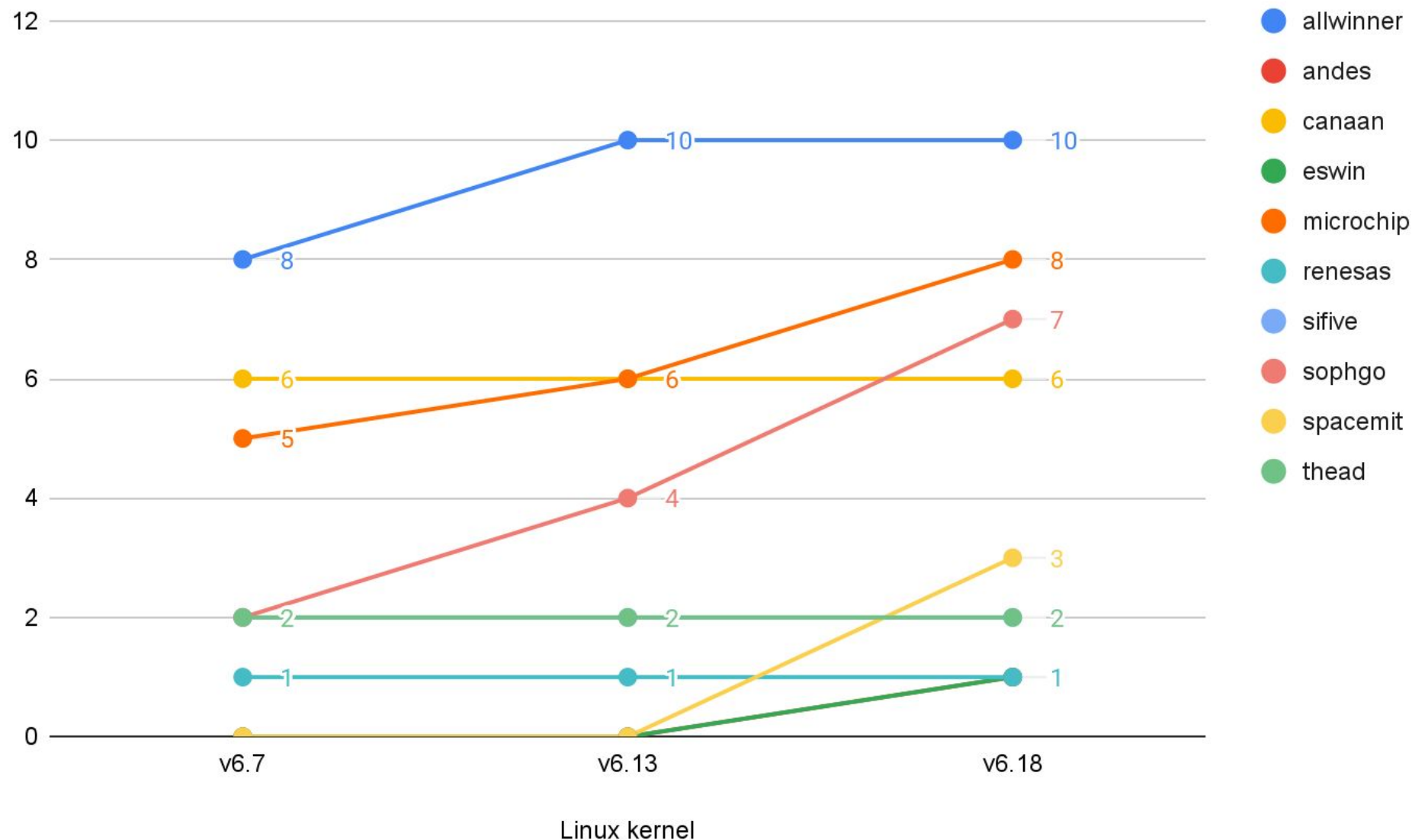
# Status of RISC-V Platforms



## SoC Platforms - RISC-V

- RISC-V has 100% DTBs check compliance so no need to compare SoCs
- I can show number of targets...

# Number of Targets - RISC-V



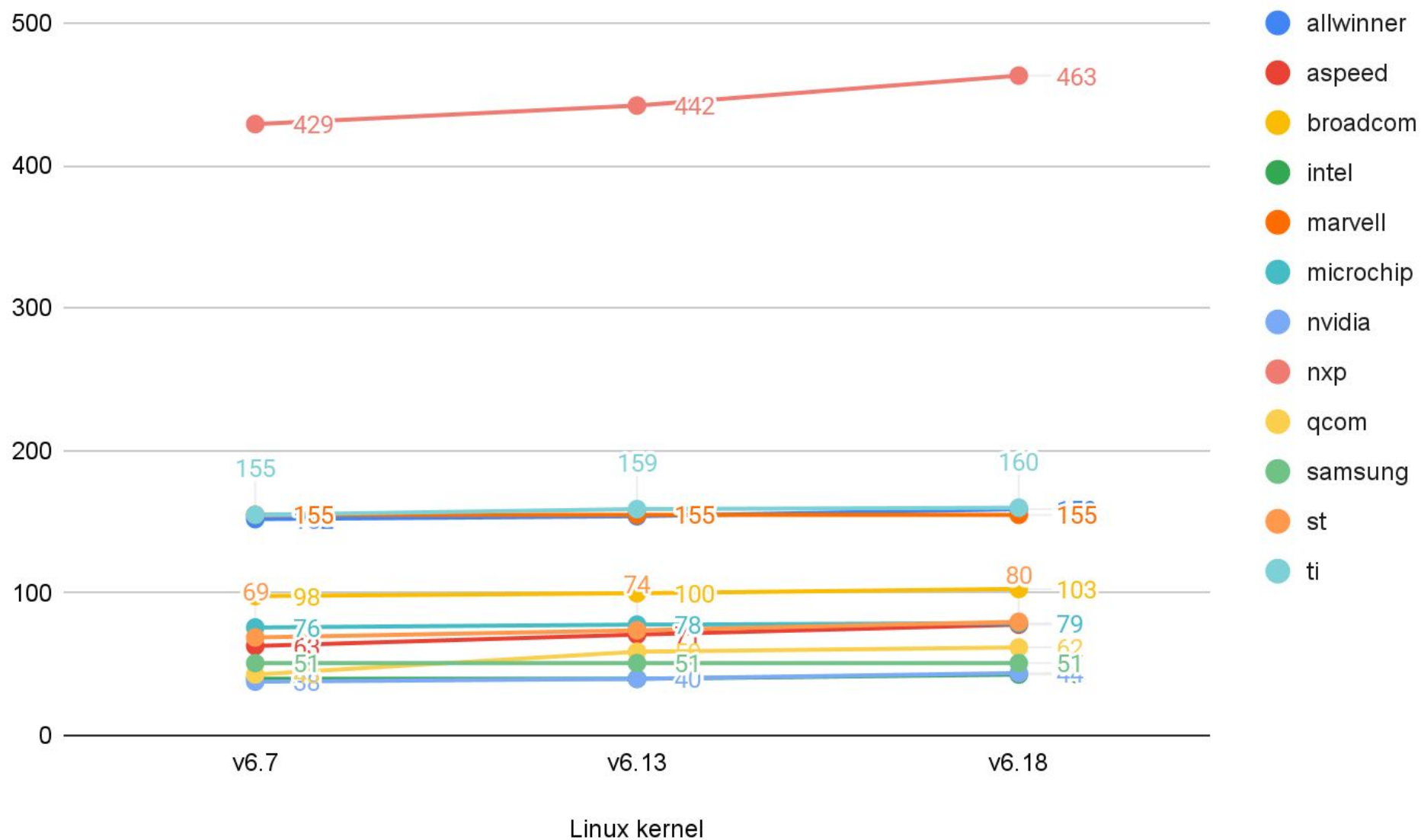
# Status of ARM (32-bit) Platforms



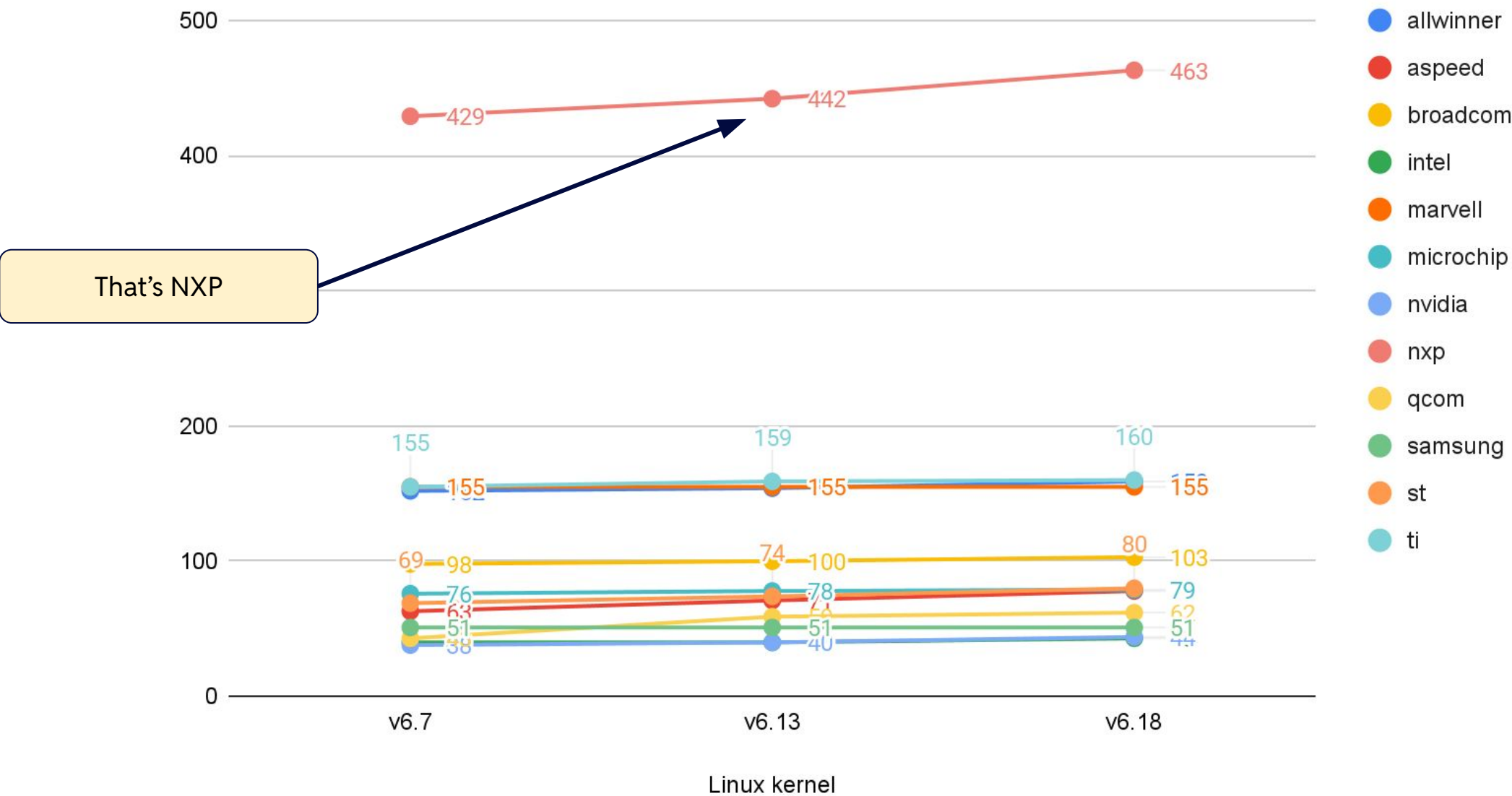
## SoC Platforms - ARM

- There is 40 subdirectories in arch/arm/boot/dts - ~40 SoC vendors
- Many not being actively developed
- Following slides show subset of architectures, e.g. most active in Linux kernel

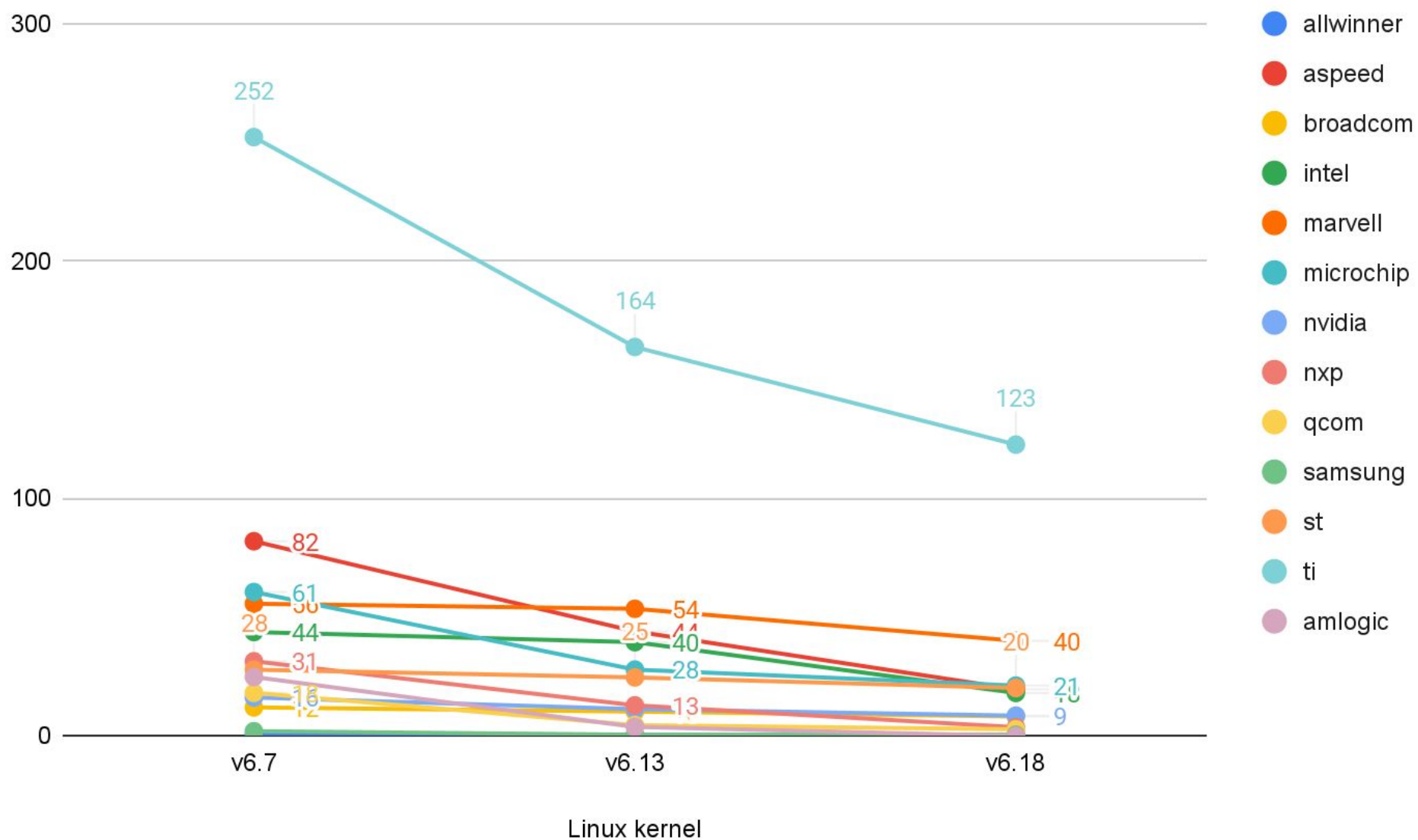
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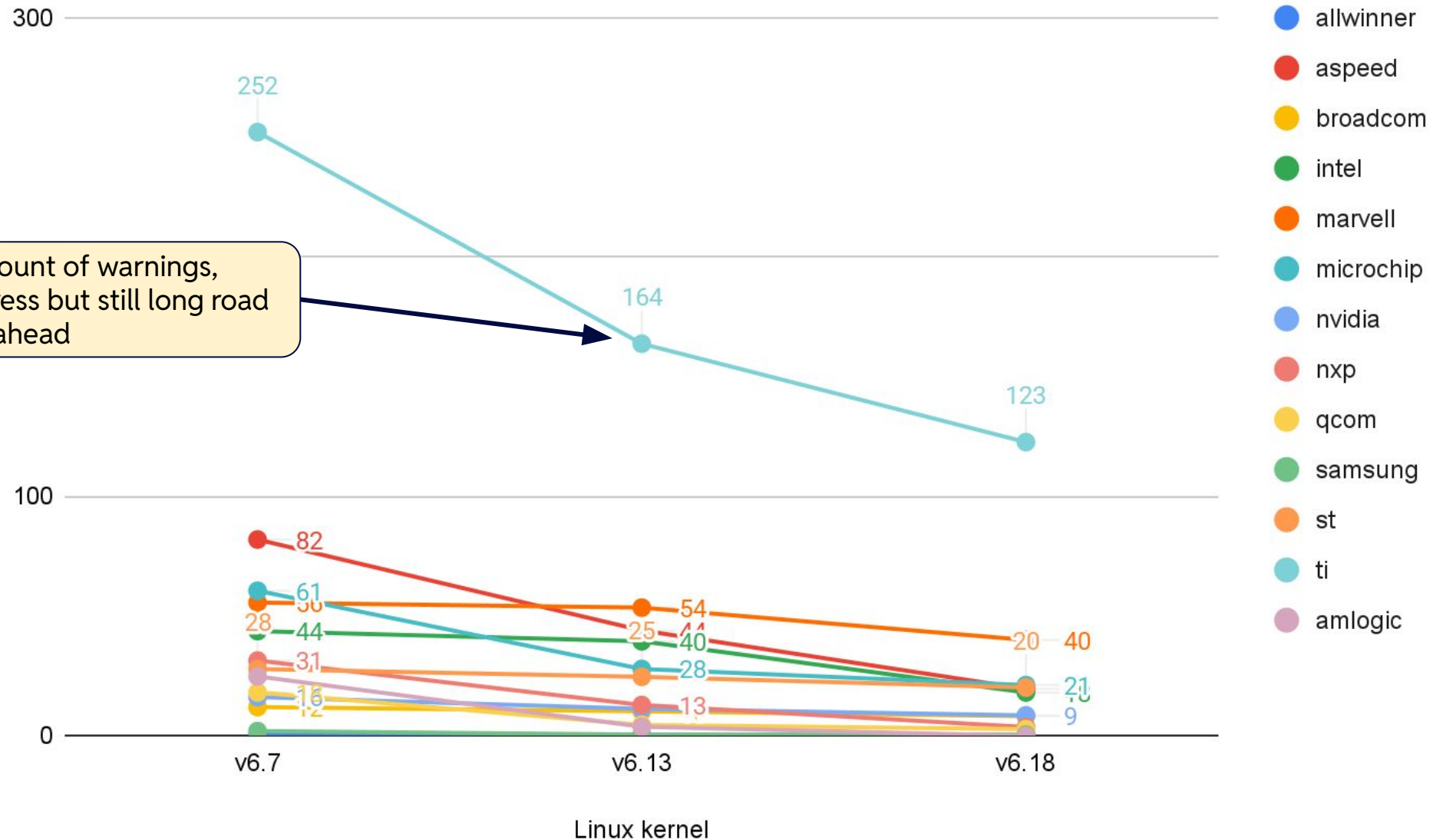


# DTBs Check Warnings / Target (Lower Better) - ARM (Excerpt)

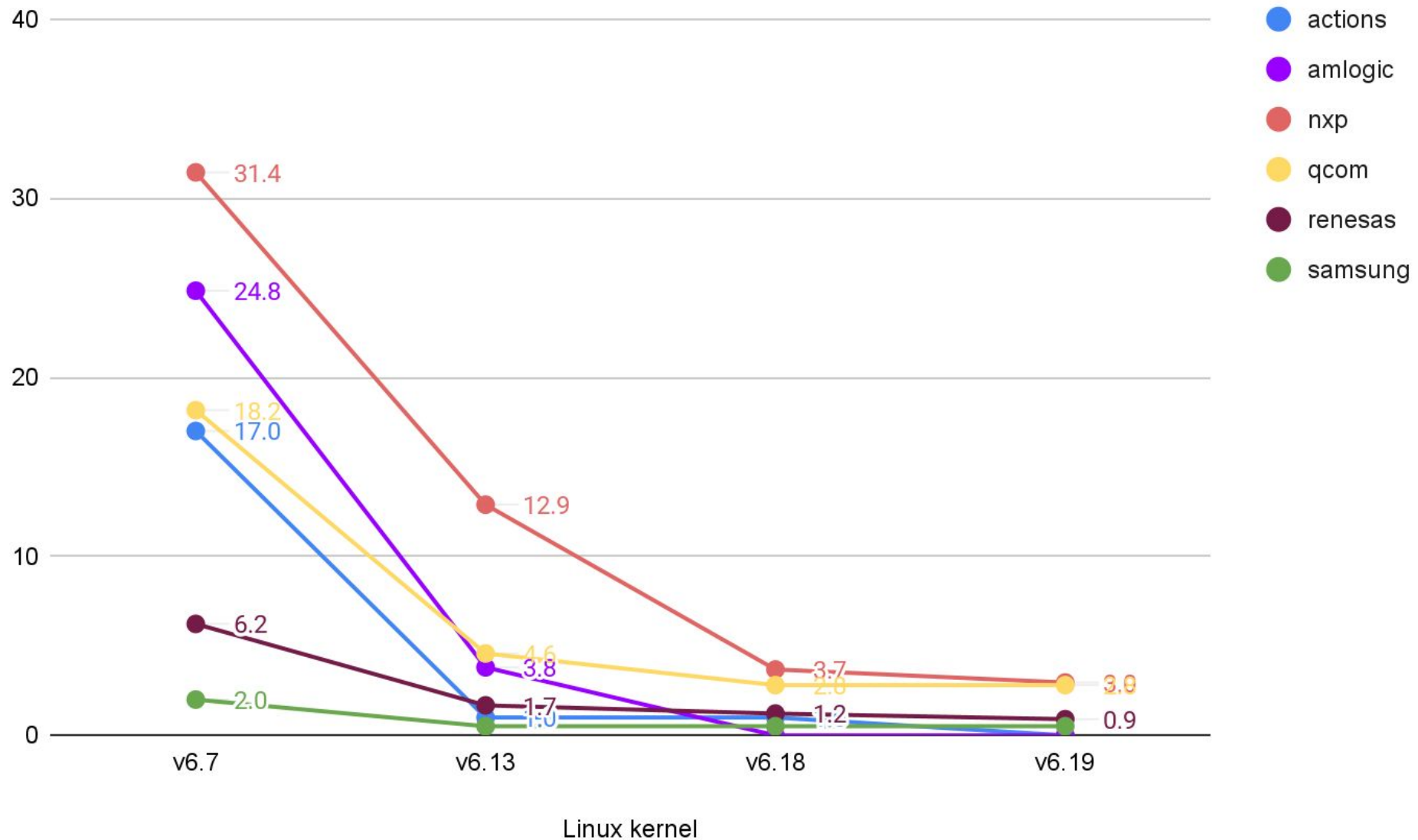




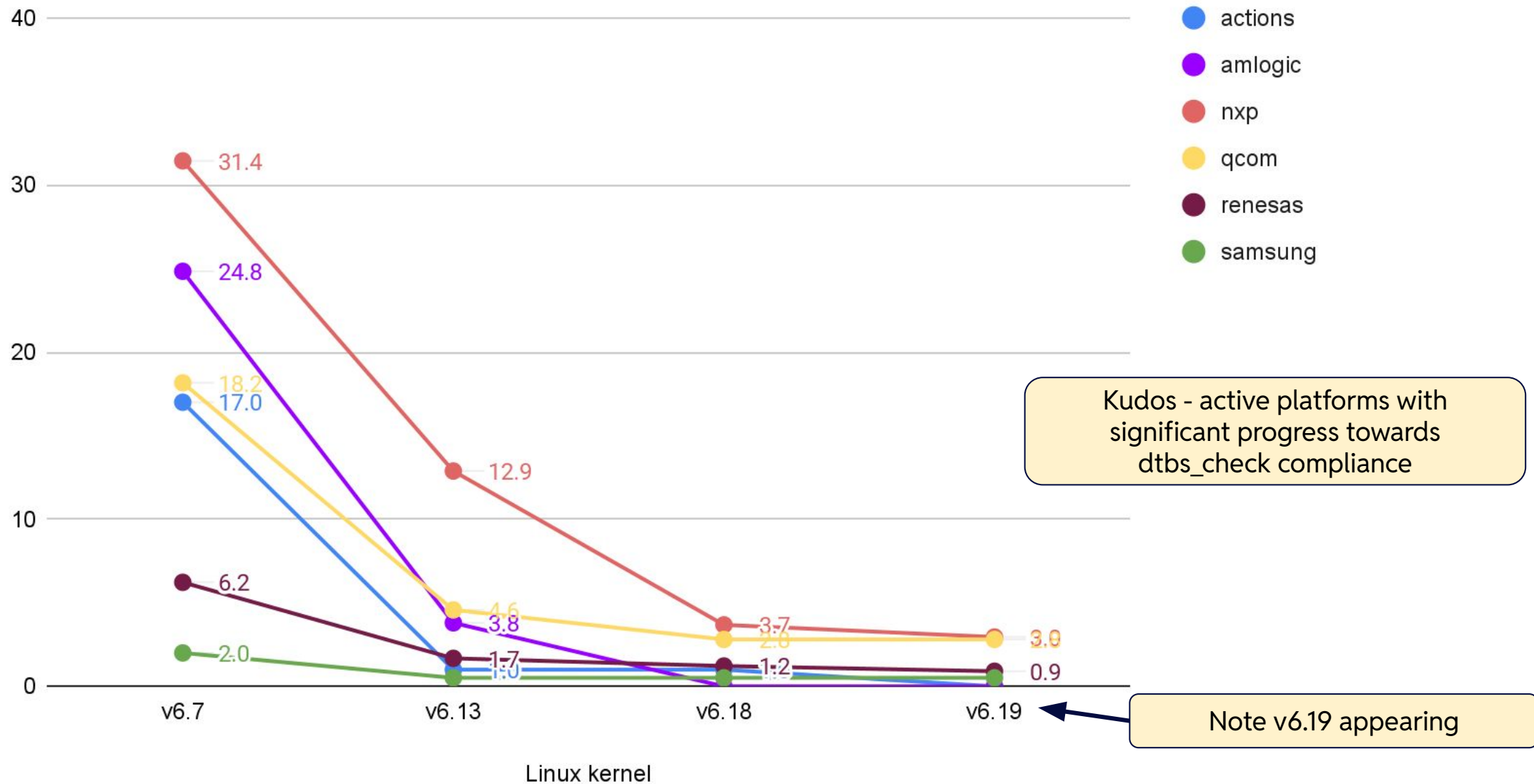
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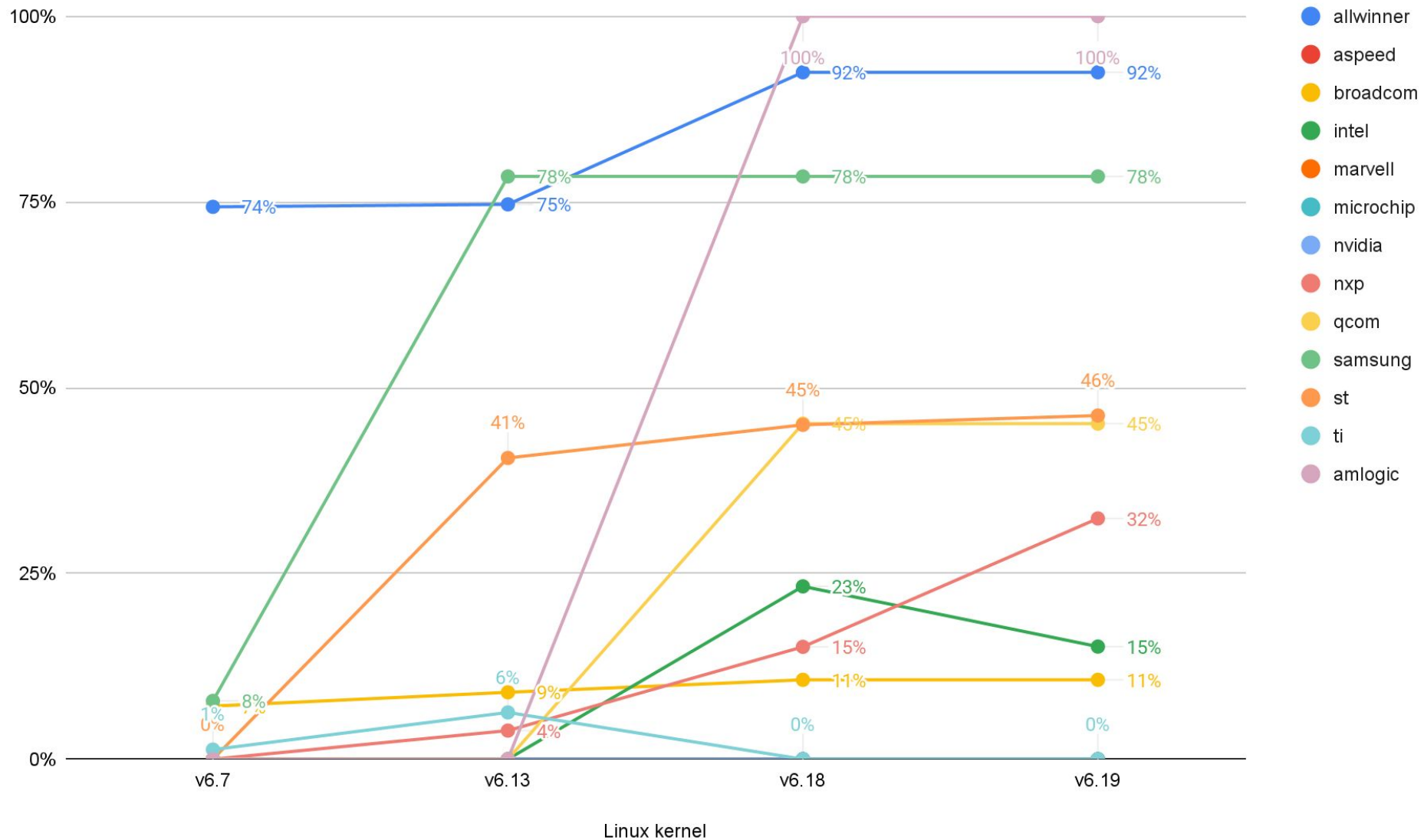
# DTBs Check Warnings / Target (Lower Better) - ARM Kudos



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# Percentage of Warning-free Targets (Higher Better) - ARM (Excerpt)



# Warning-free Platforms (Higher Better) - ARM, v6.19 (next)

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|
| Actions      | 100%                               | 5           |
| Airoha       | 100%                               | 1           |
| Amlogic      | 100%                               | 6           |
| HPE          | 100%                               | 1           |
| Allwinner    | 92.5%                              | 159         |

## Platforms with Only Warnings - ARM, v6.19 (next)

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|
| alphascale   | 0%                                 | 1           |
| amazon       | 0%                                 | 1           |
| arm          | 0%                                 | 24          |
| aspeed       | 0%                                 | 80          |
| axis         | 0%                                 | 1           |
| calxeda      | 0%                                 | 2           |
| cnxt         | 0%                                 | 1           |
| gemini       | 0%                                 | 10          |
| marvell      | 0%                                 | 155         |
| microchip    | 0%                                 | 79          |
| moxa         | 0%                                 | 1           |
| nspire       | 0%                                 | 3           |

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|
| nuvoton      | 0%                                 | 6           |
| nvidia       | 0%                                 | 45          |
| realtek      | 0%                                 | 2           |
| sigmastar    | 0%                                 | 8           |
| sunplus      | 0%                                 | 1           |
| synaptics    | 0%                                 | 4           |
| ti           | 0%                                 | 161         |
| unisoc       | 0%                                 | 2           |
| vt8500       | 0%                                 | 6           |
| xen          | 0%                                 | 1           |
| xilinx       | 0%                                 | 15          |

## Commentary

- Fixing some DTBs check warnings might require testing and many ARM platforms are now legacy
  - Some are still actively developed, like Aspeed, but not much happening in fixing warnings
- Effort is mostly moved to ARM64

# Status of ARM64 Platforms





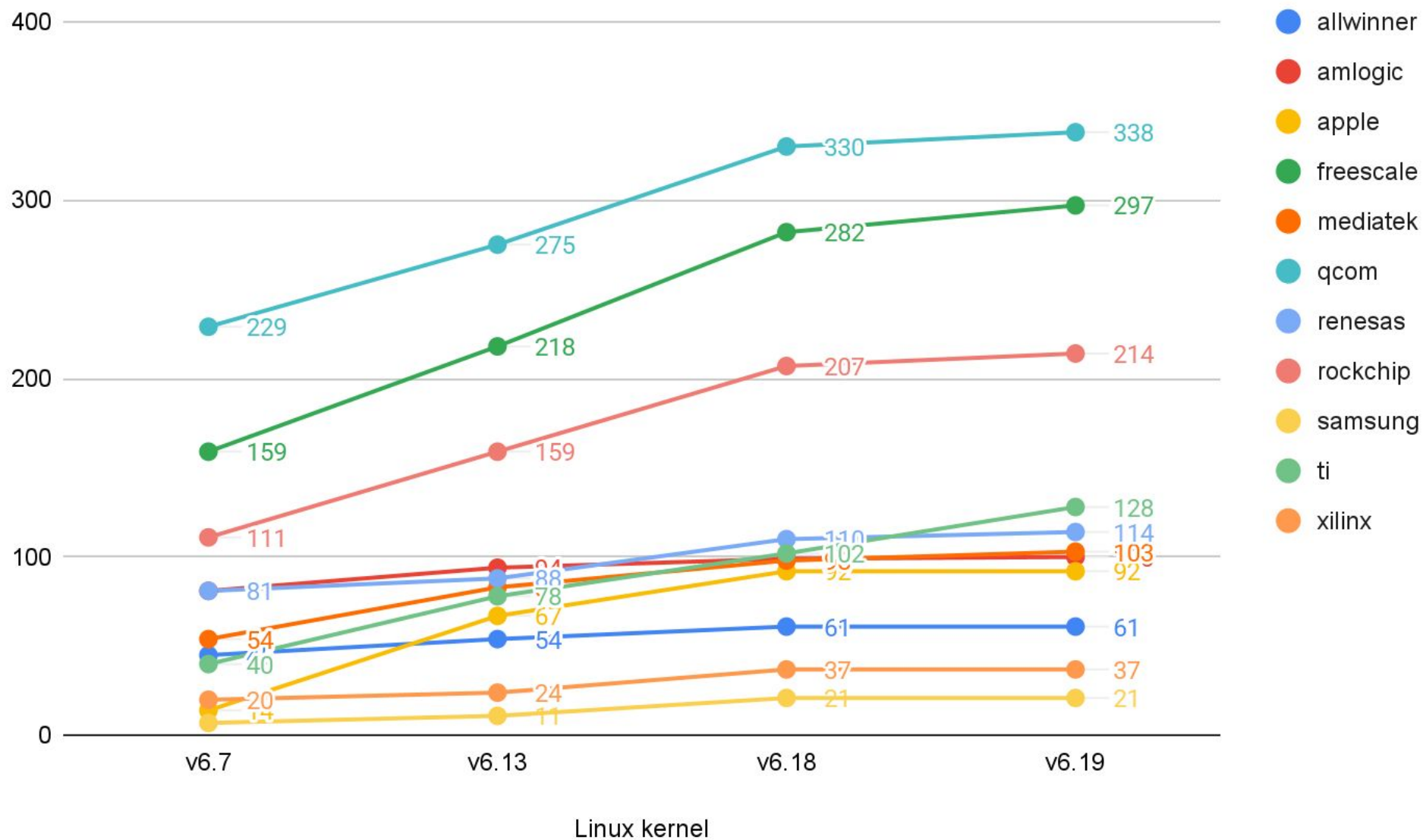
## SoC Platforms - ARM64

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  - Freescale = NXP (old naming used here)

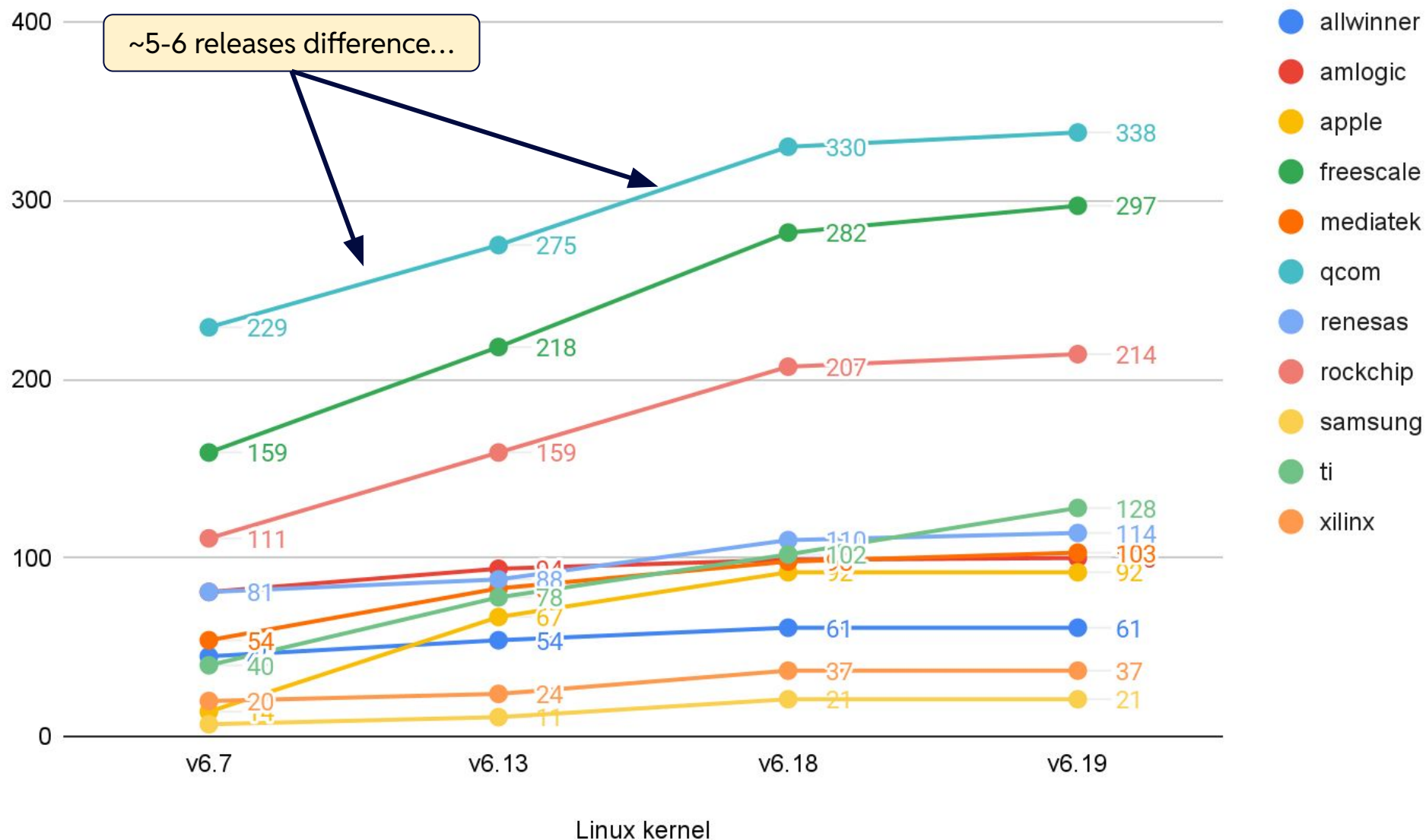
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  - Tesla and Exynos are both Samsung
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- Some not being actively developed, at least in DTS
  - They still could be well supported ACPI platform...
- Following slides show subset of architectures, e.g. most active in Linux kernel

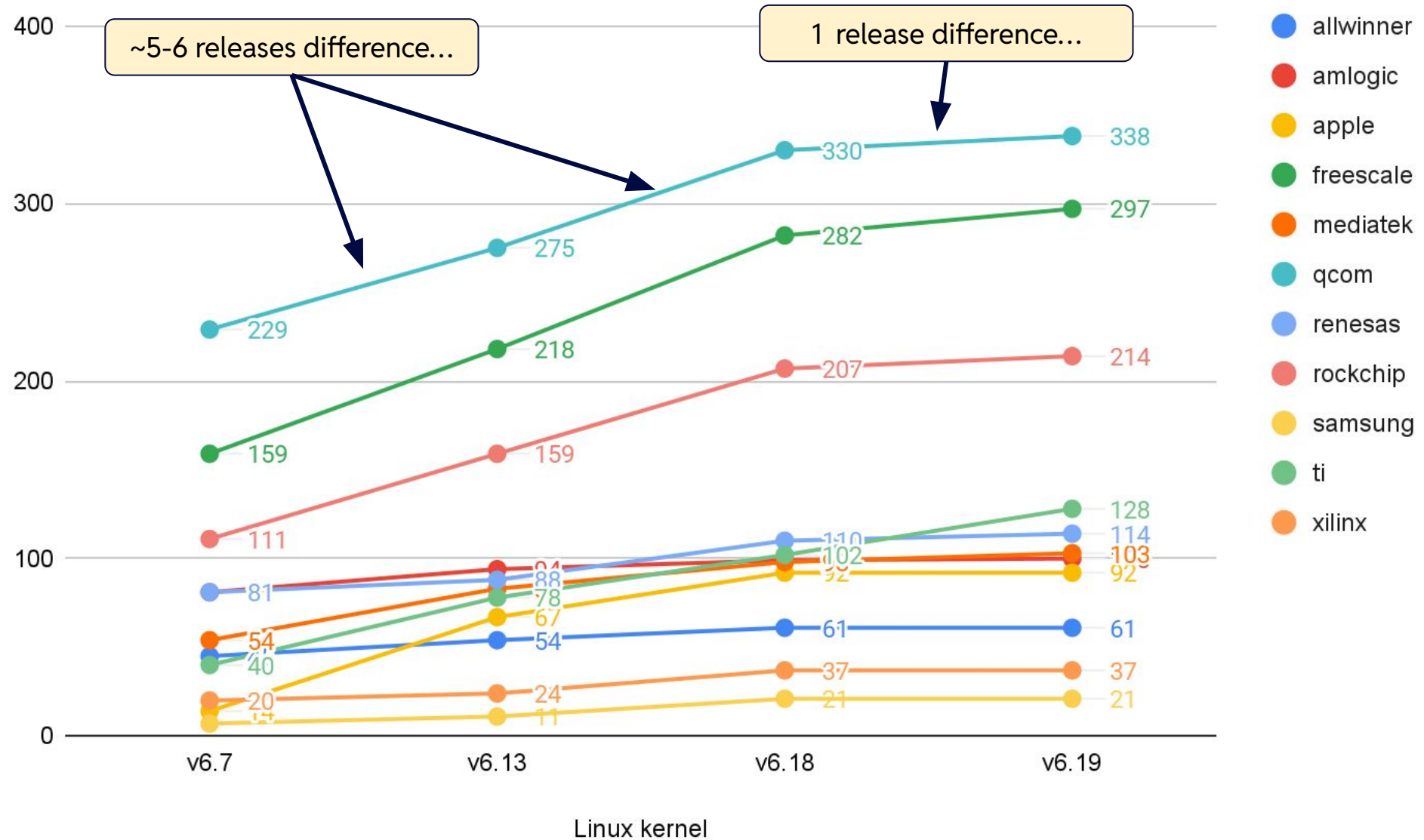
# Number of Targets - ARM64 (Most Active)



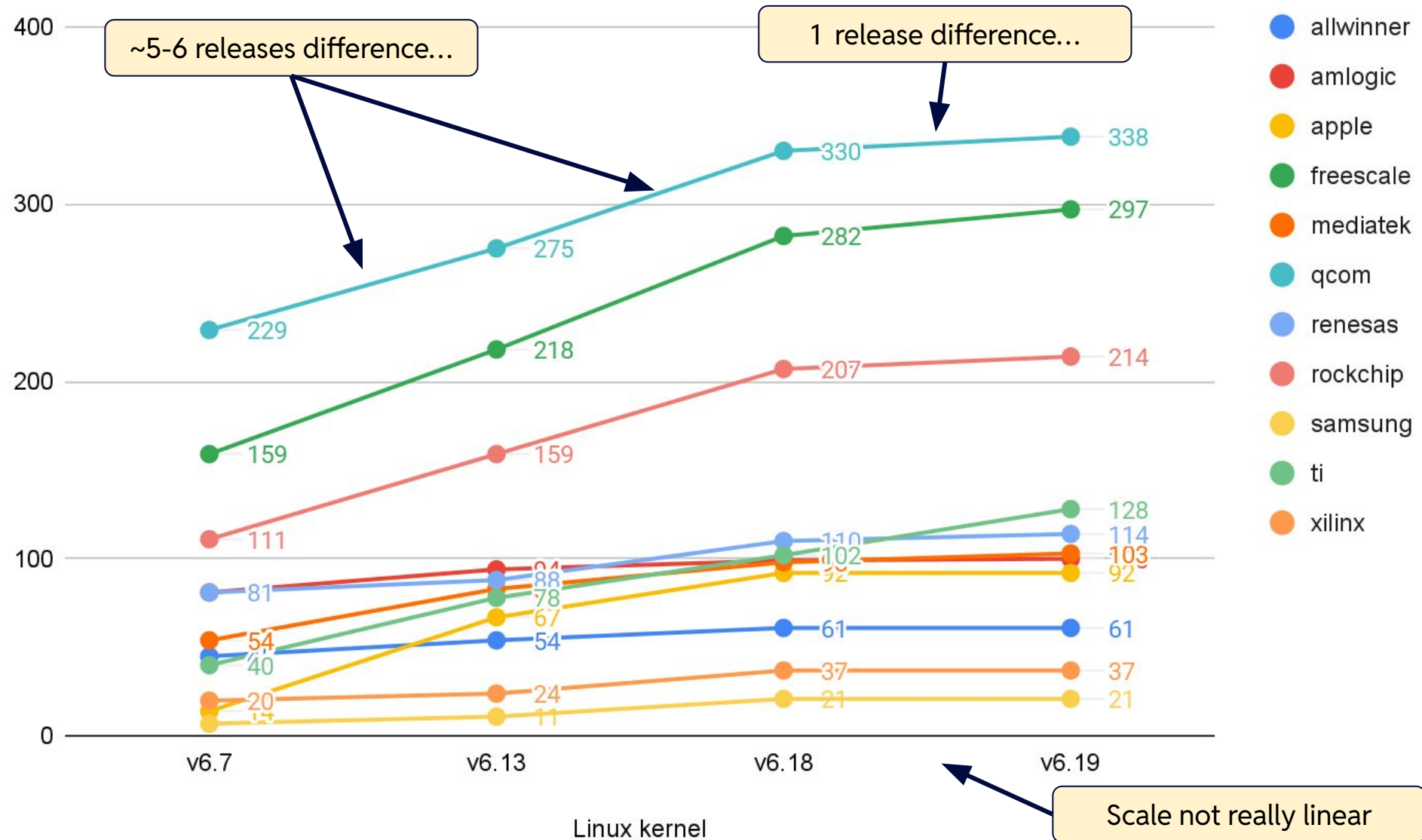
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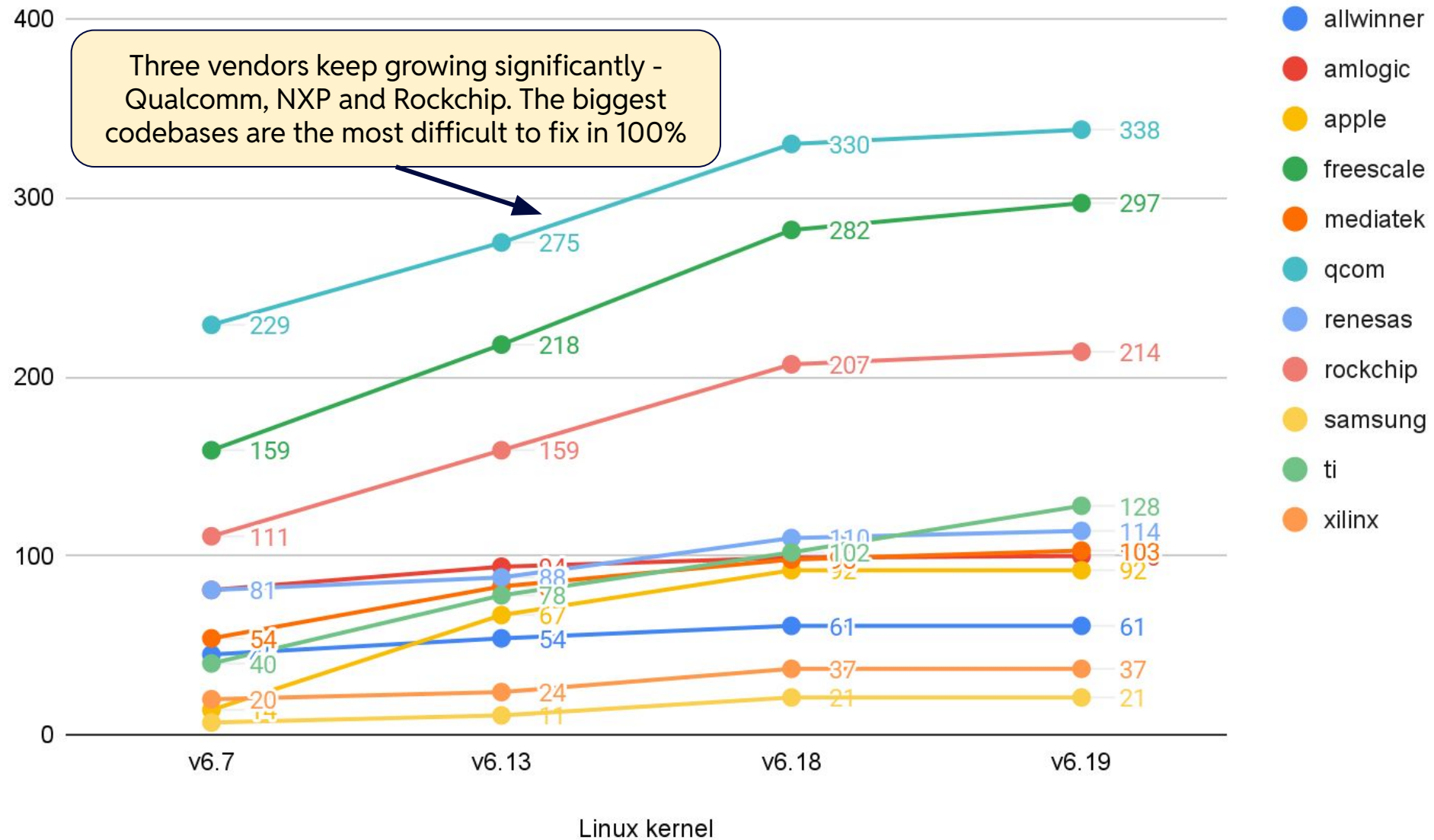
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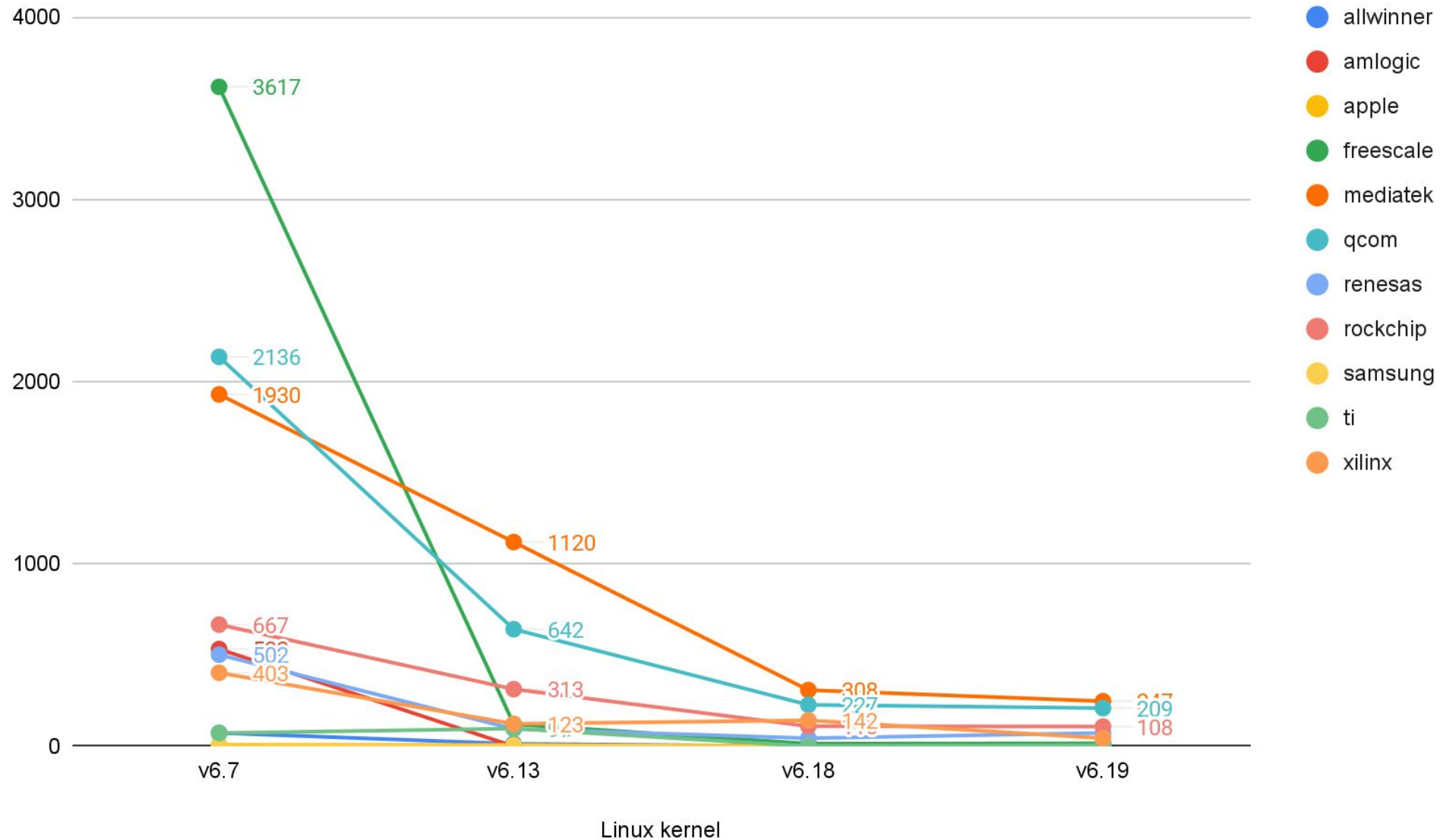


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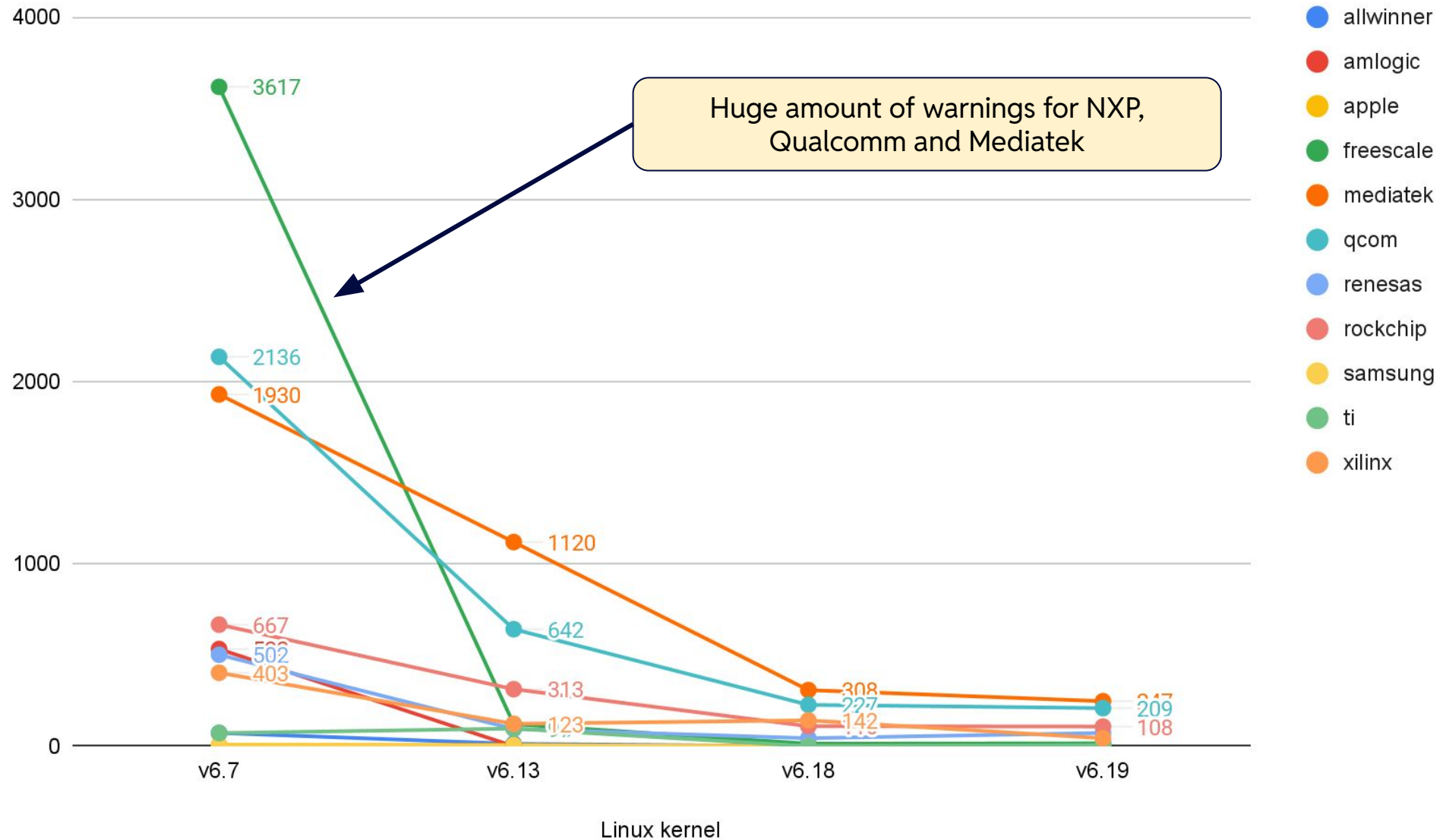


# Total DTBs Check Warnings (Lower Better) - ARM64 (Most Active)

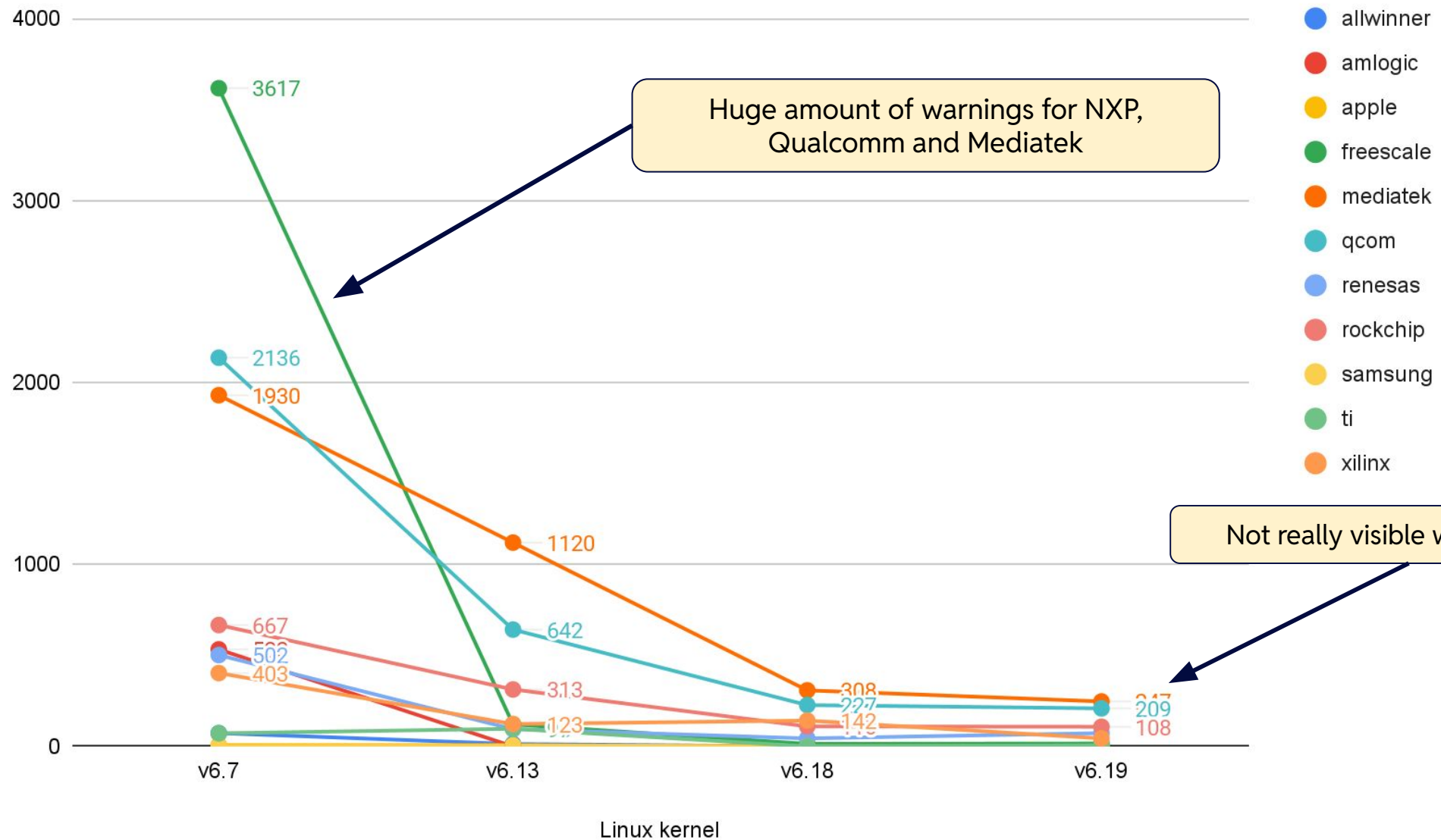




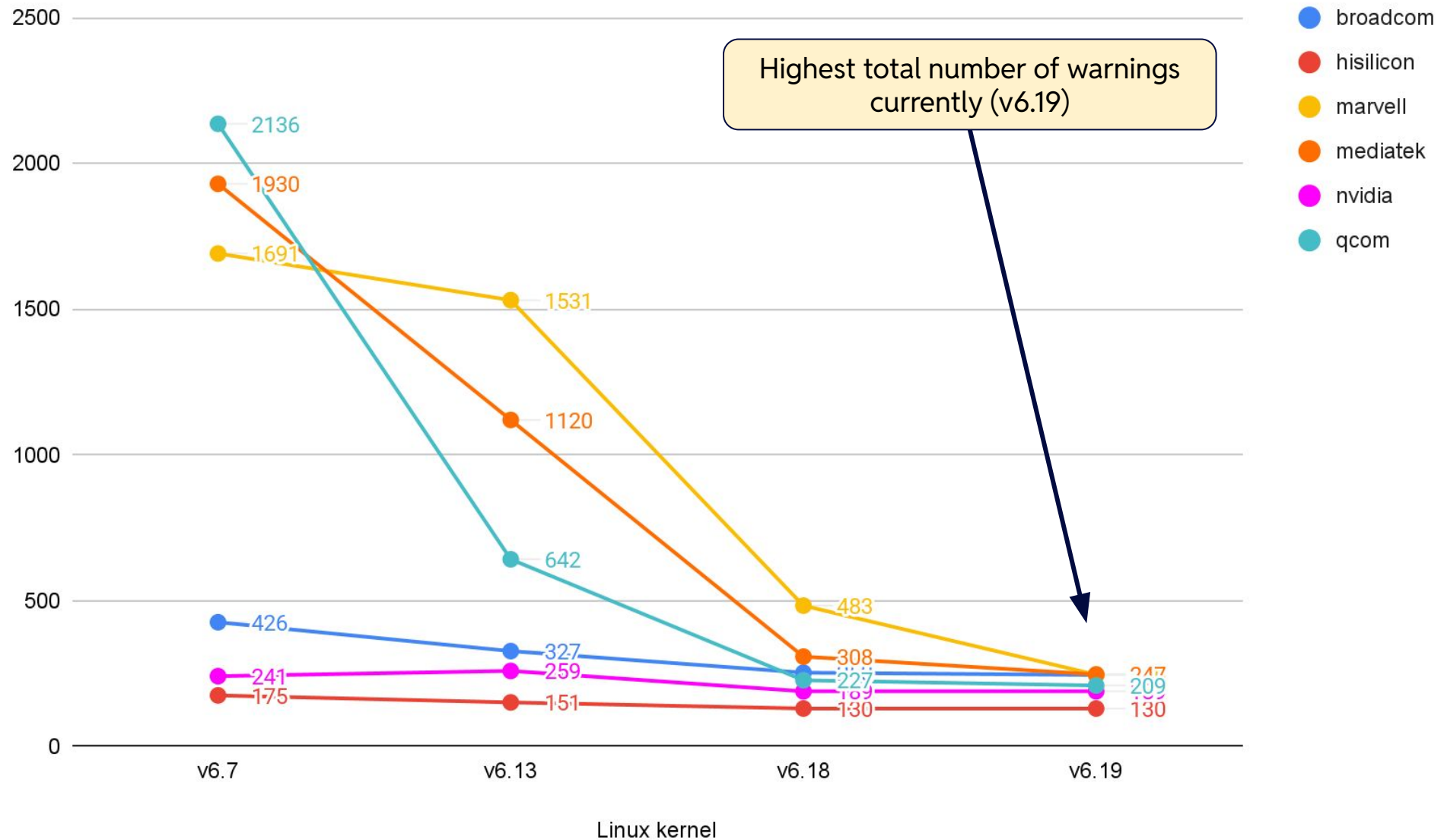
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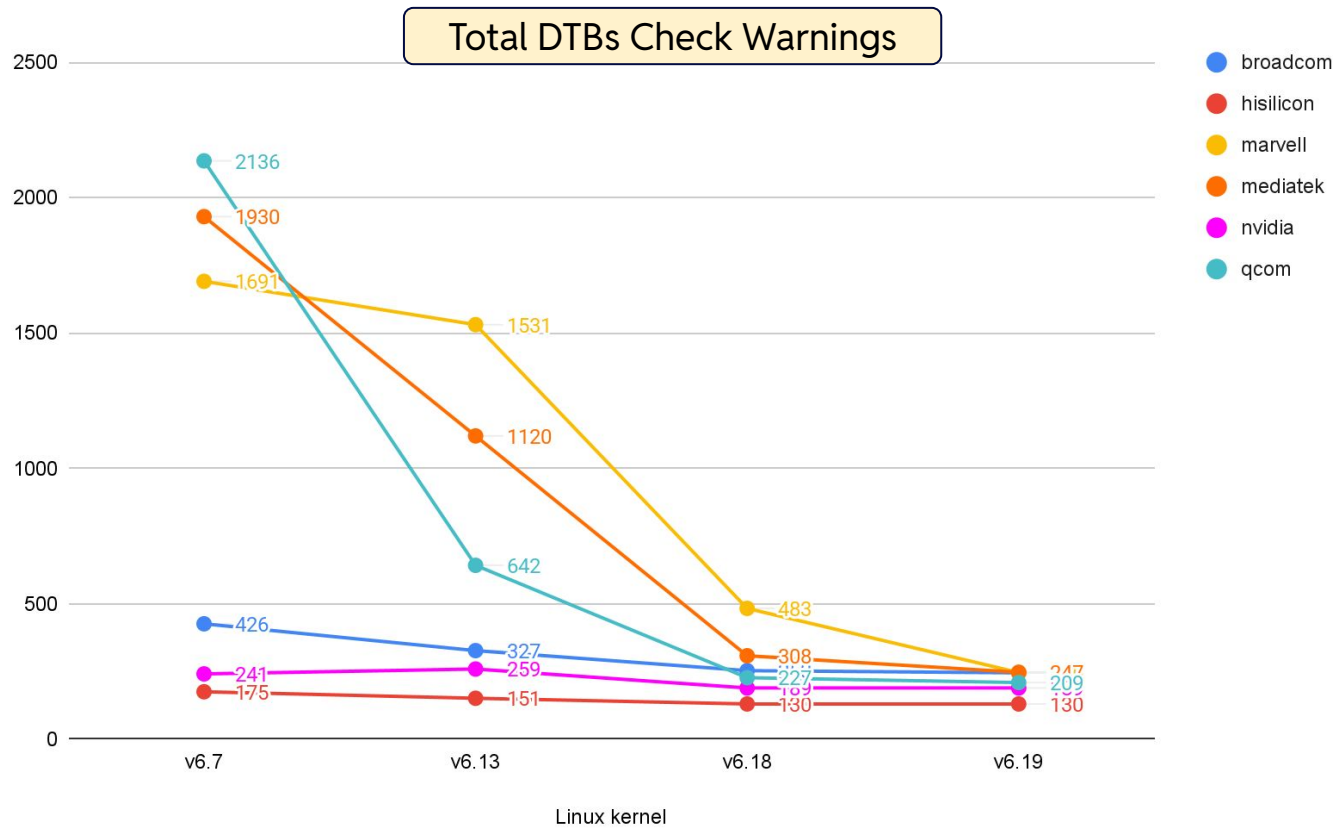
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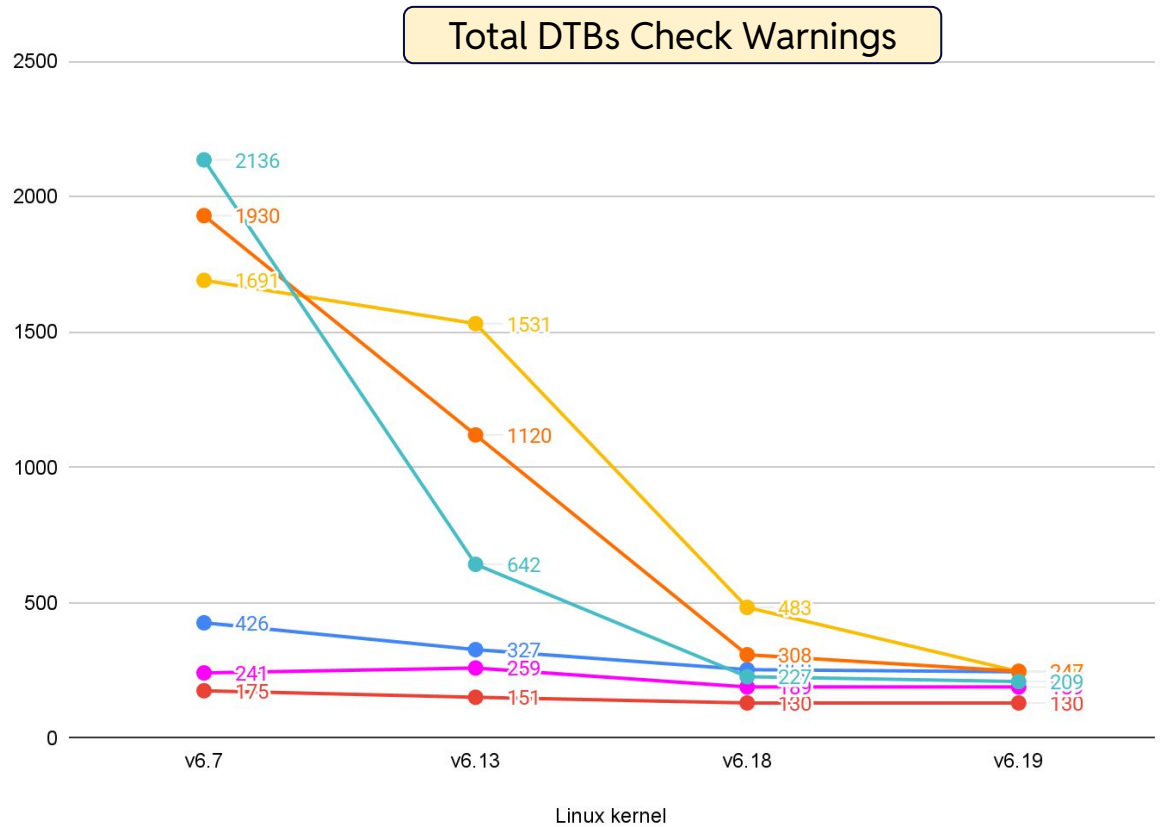
# Total DTBs Check Warnings (Lower Better) - Highest To. Numbers



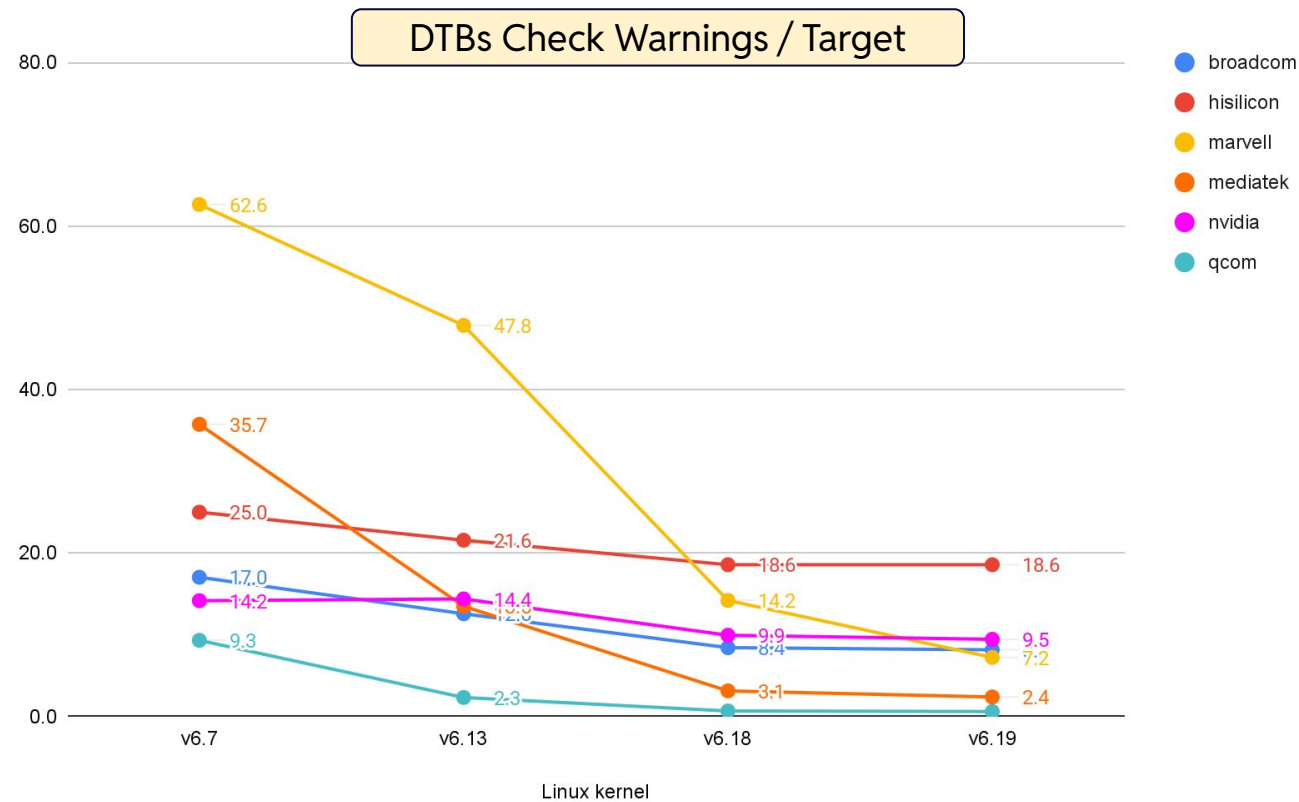
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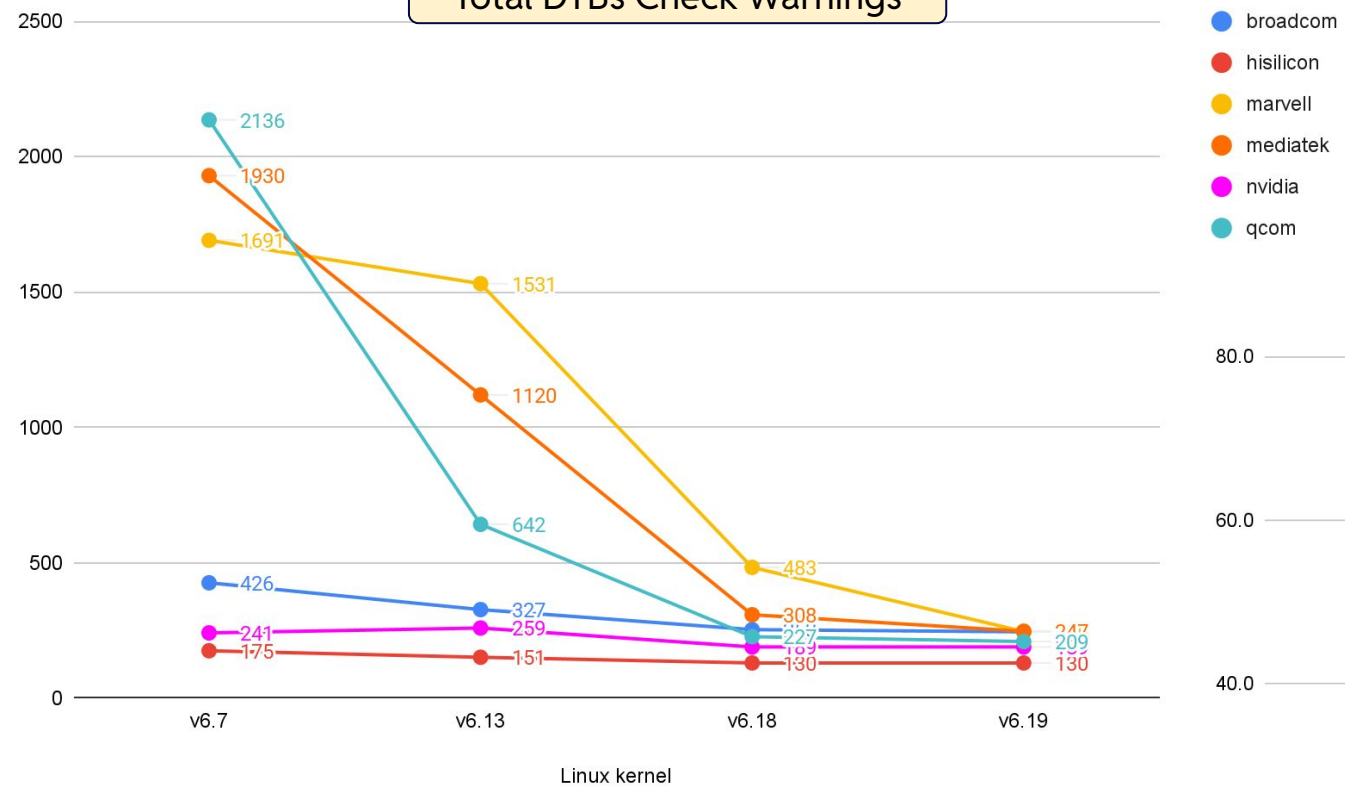
- broadcom
- hisilicon
- marvell
- mediatek
- nvidia
- qcom



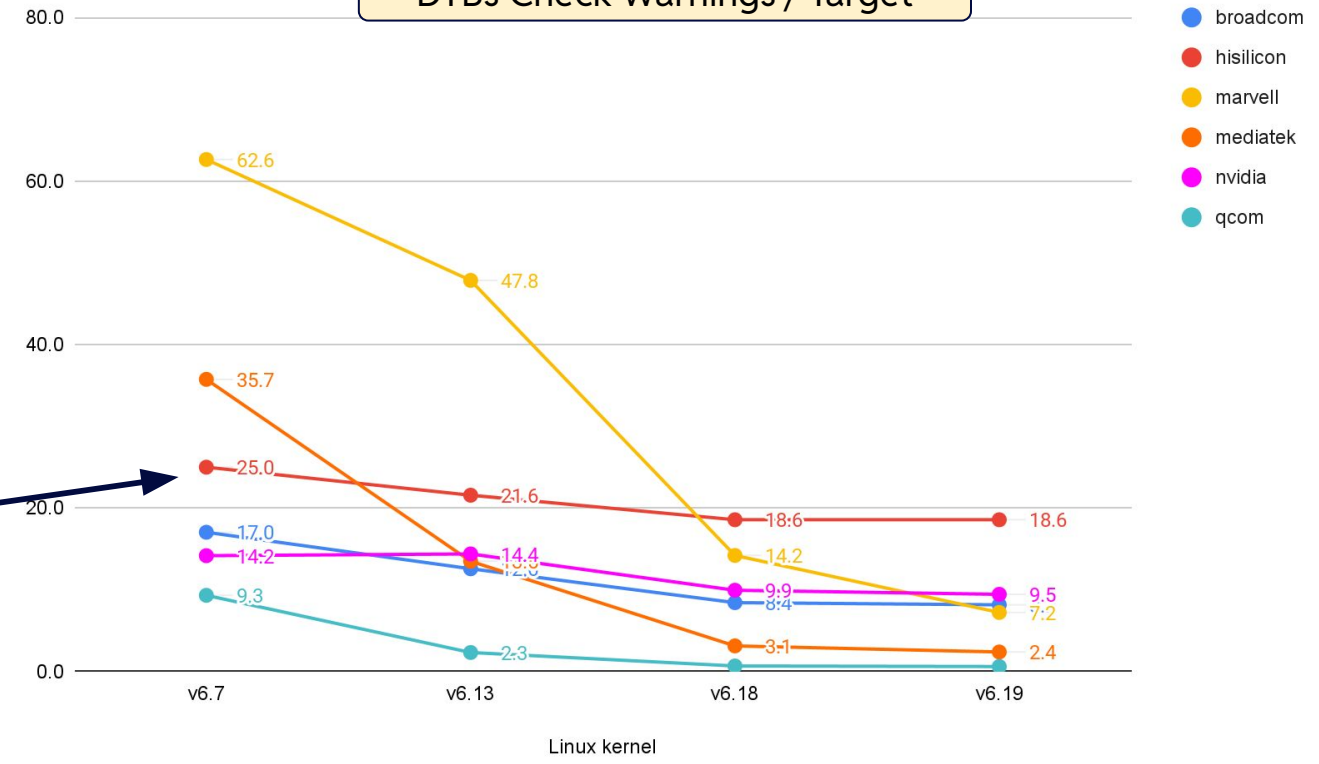
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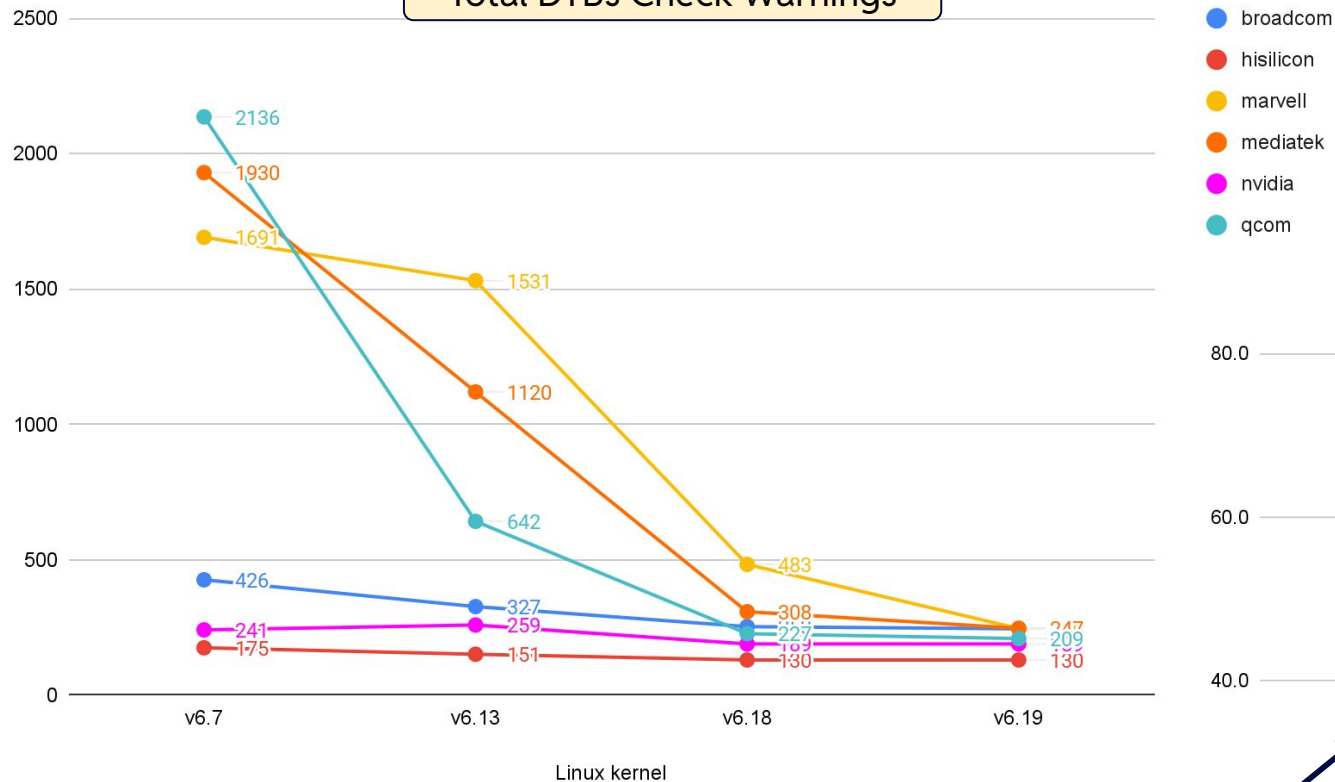
DTBs Check Warnings / Target



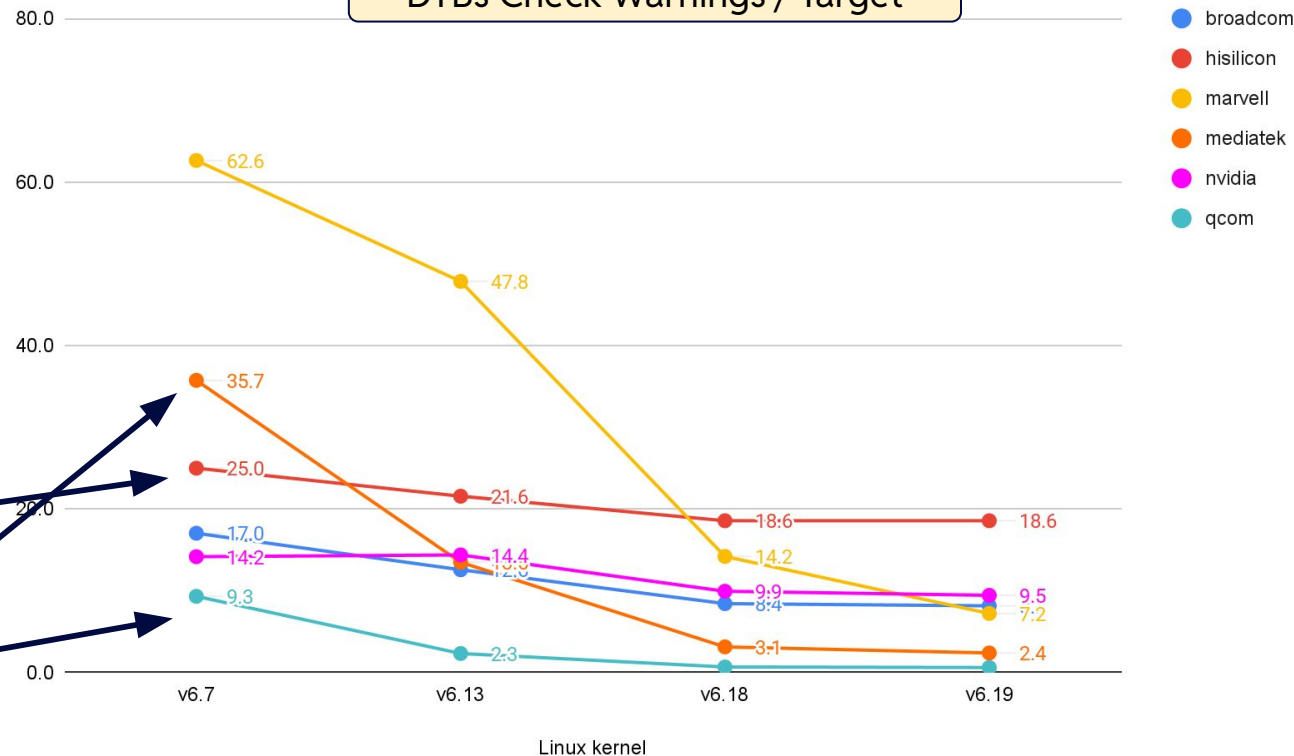
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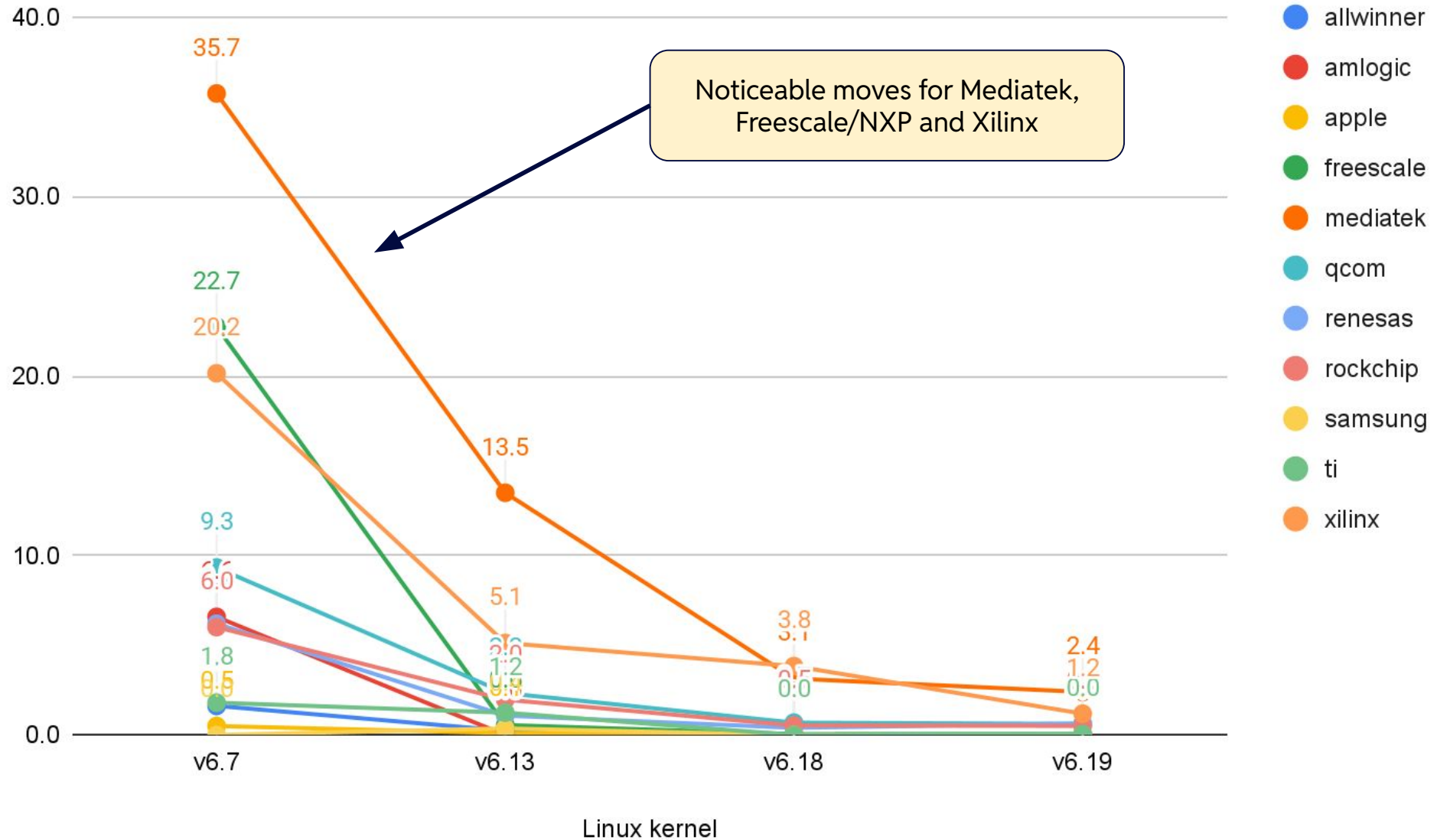


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Qualcomm and MediaTek, very high in total numbers, are doing actually well

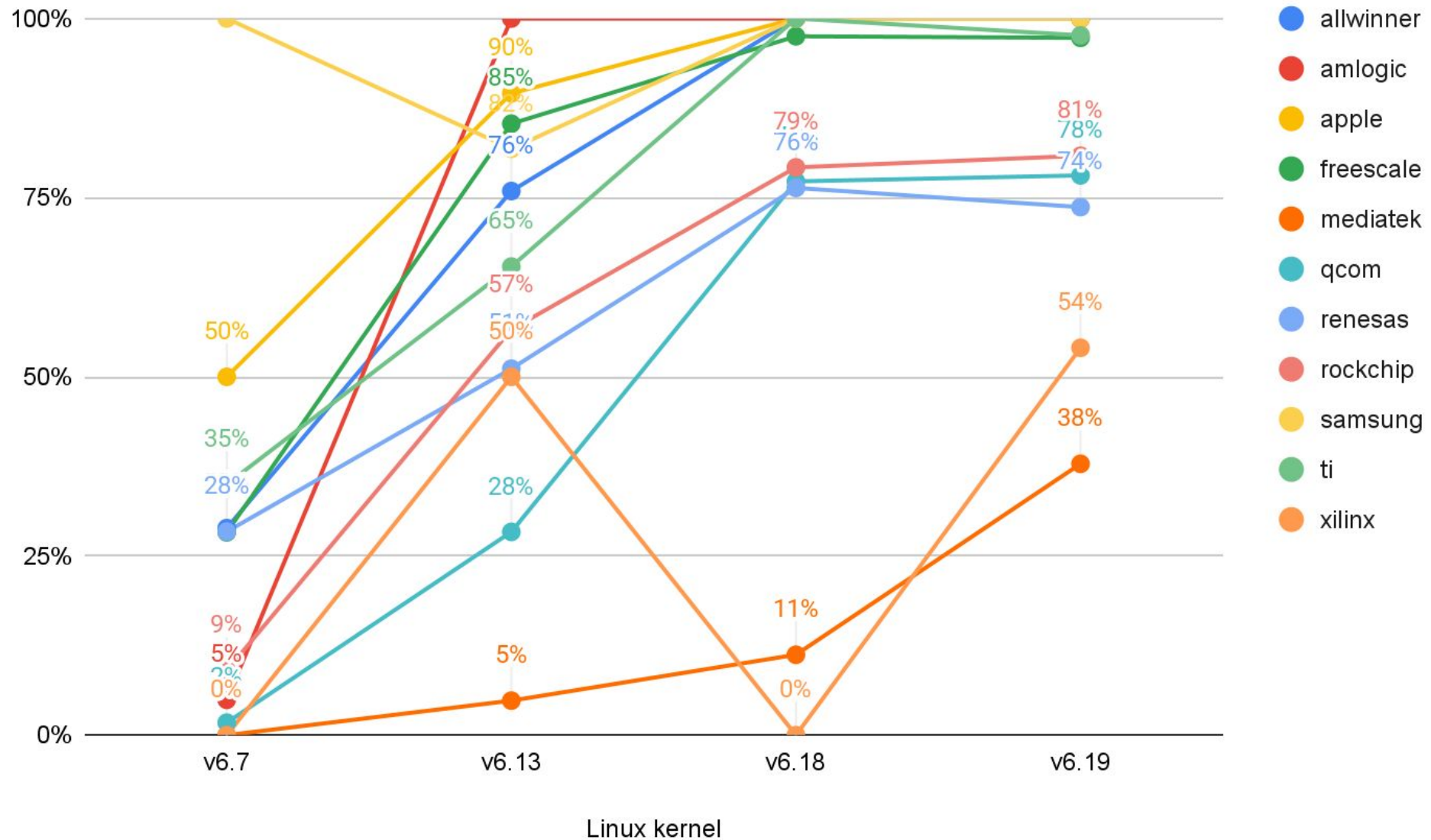


# DTBs Check Warnings / Target (Lower Better) - ARM64 (Most Active)

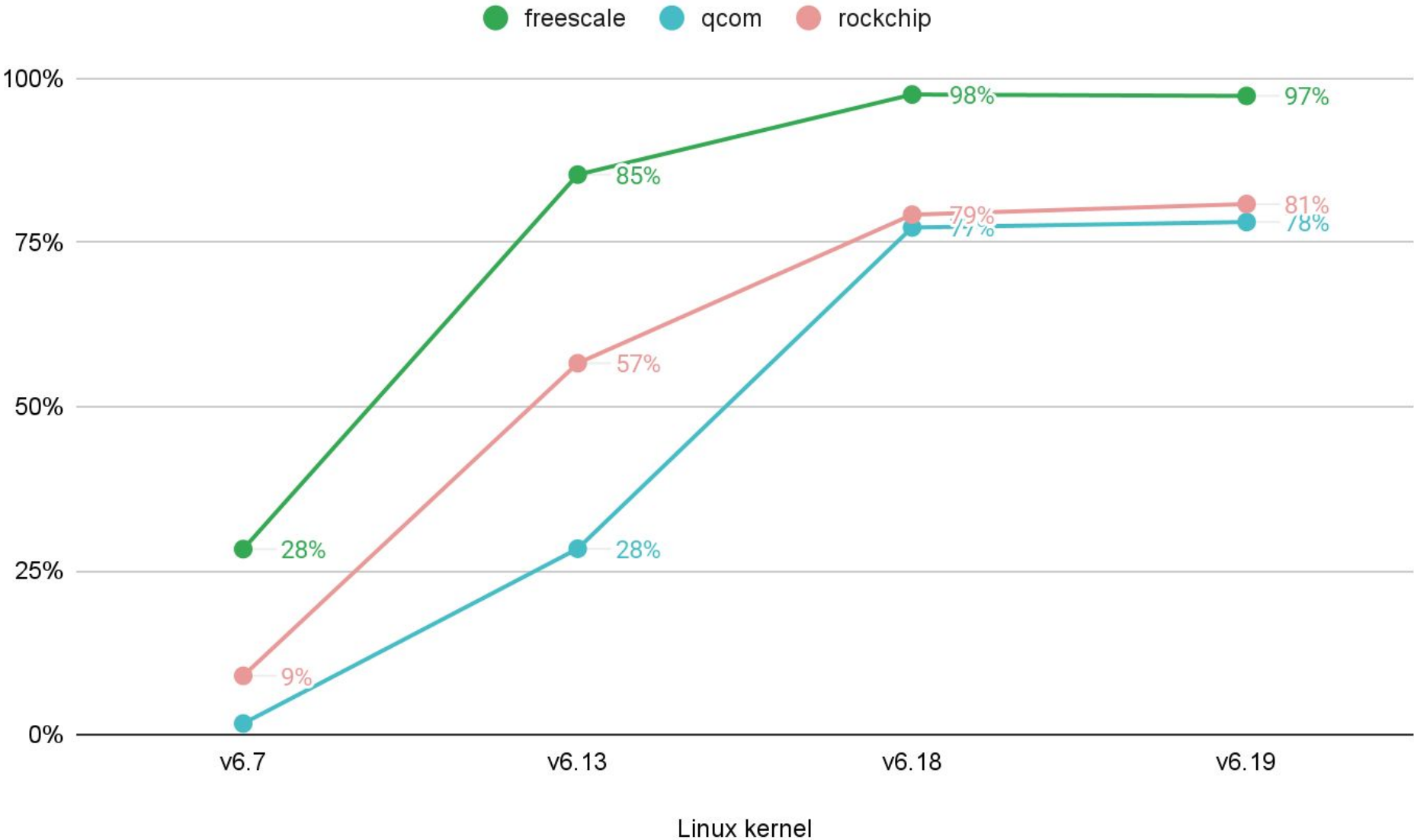




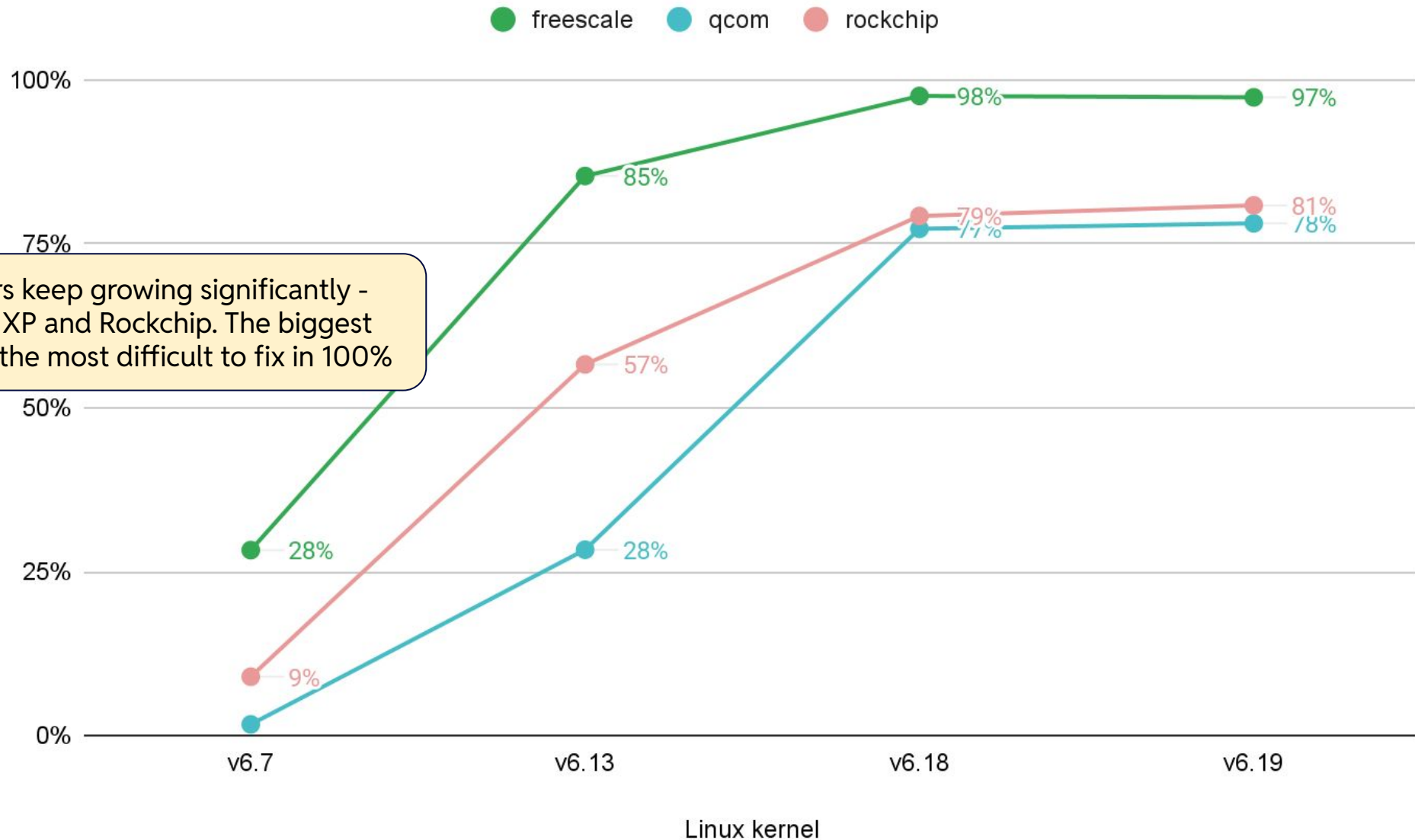
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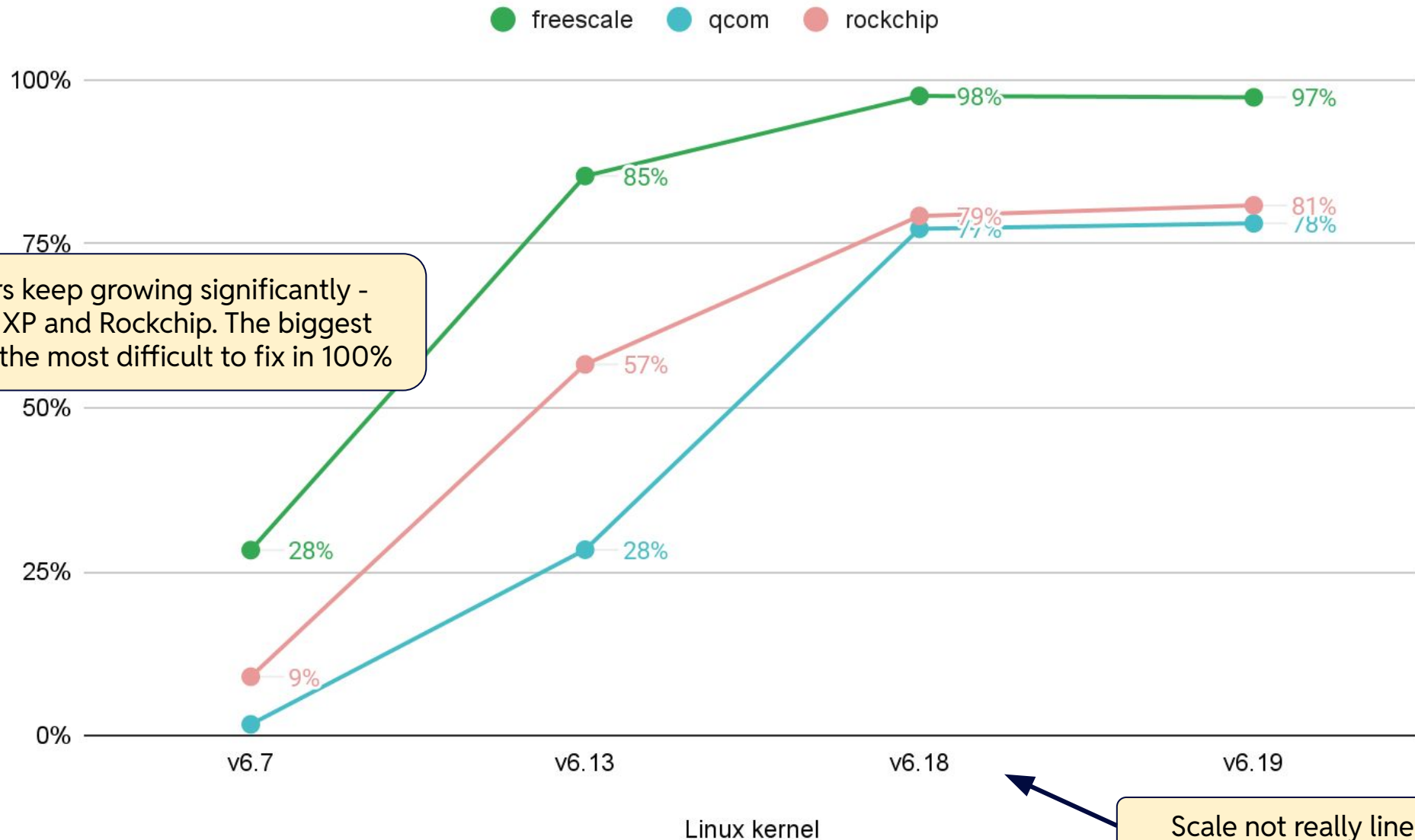


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Three vendors keep growing significantly - Qualcomm, NXP and Rockchip. The biggest codebases are the most difficult to fix in 100%

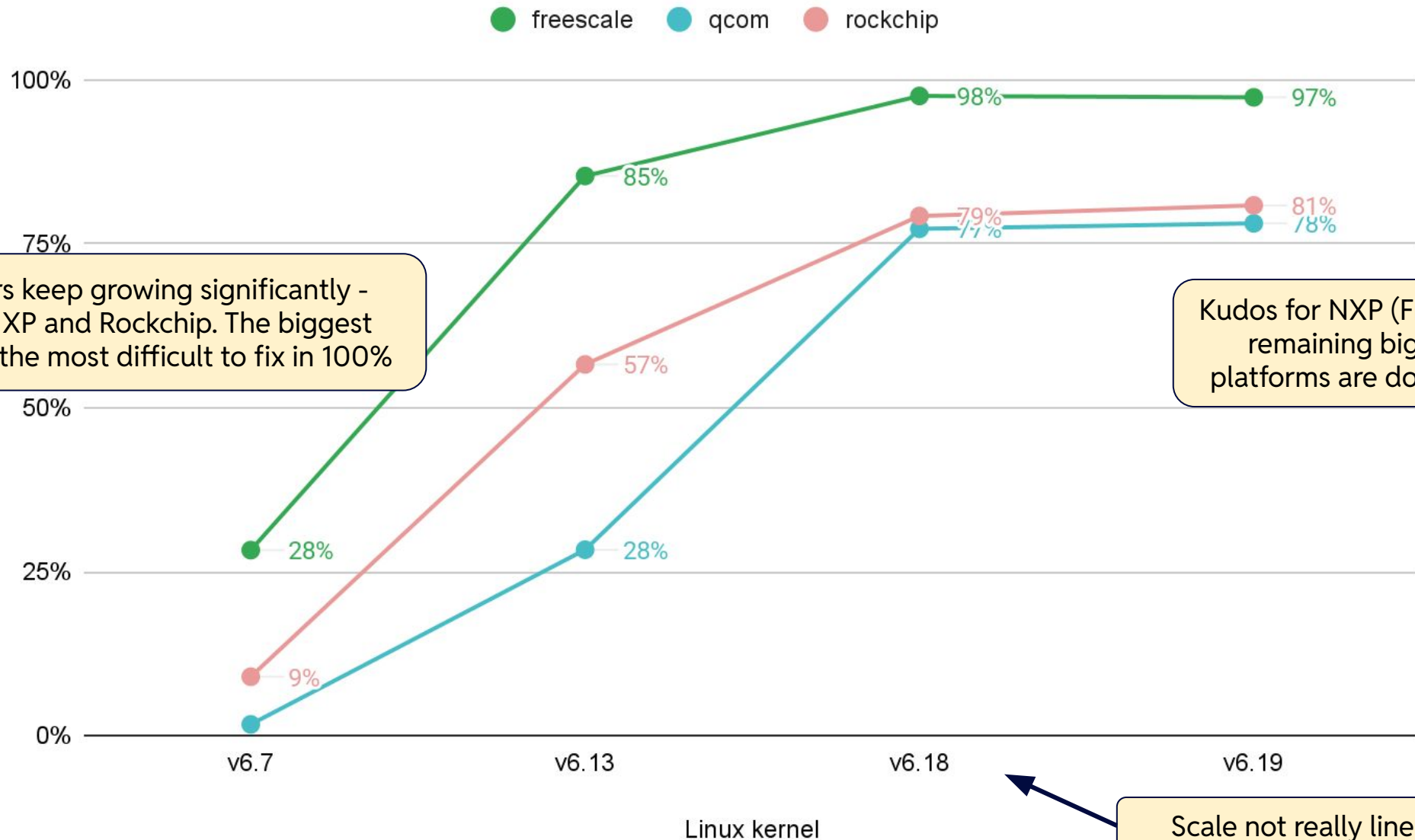
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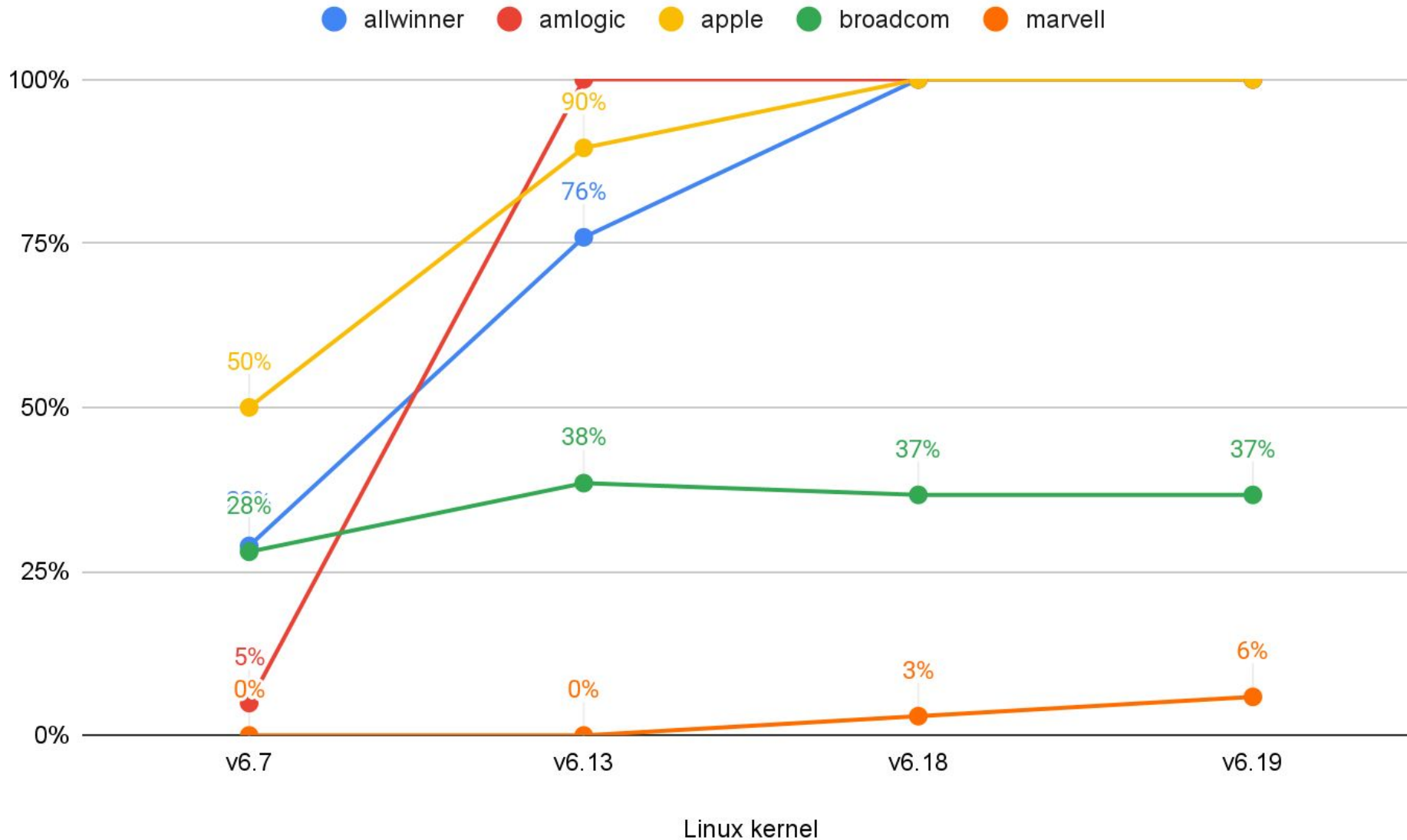
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Scale not really linear

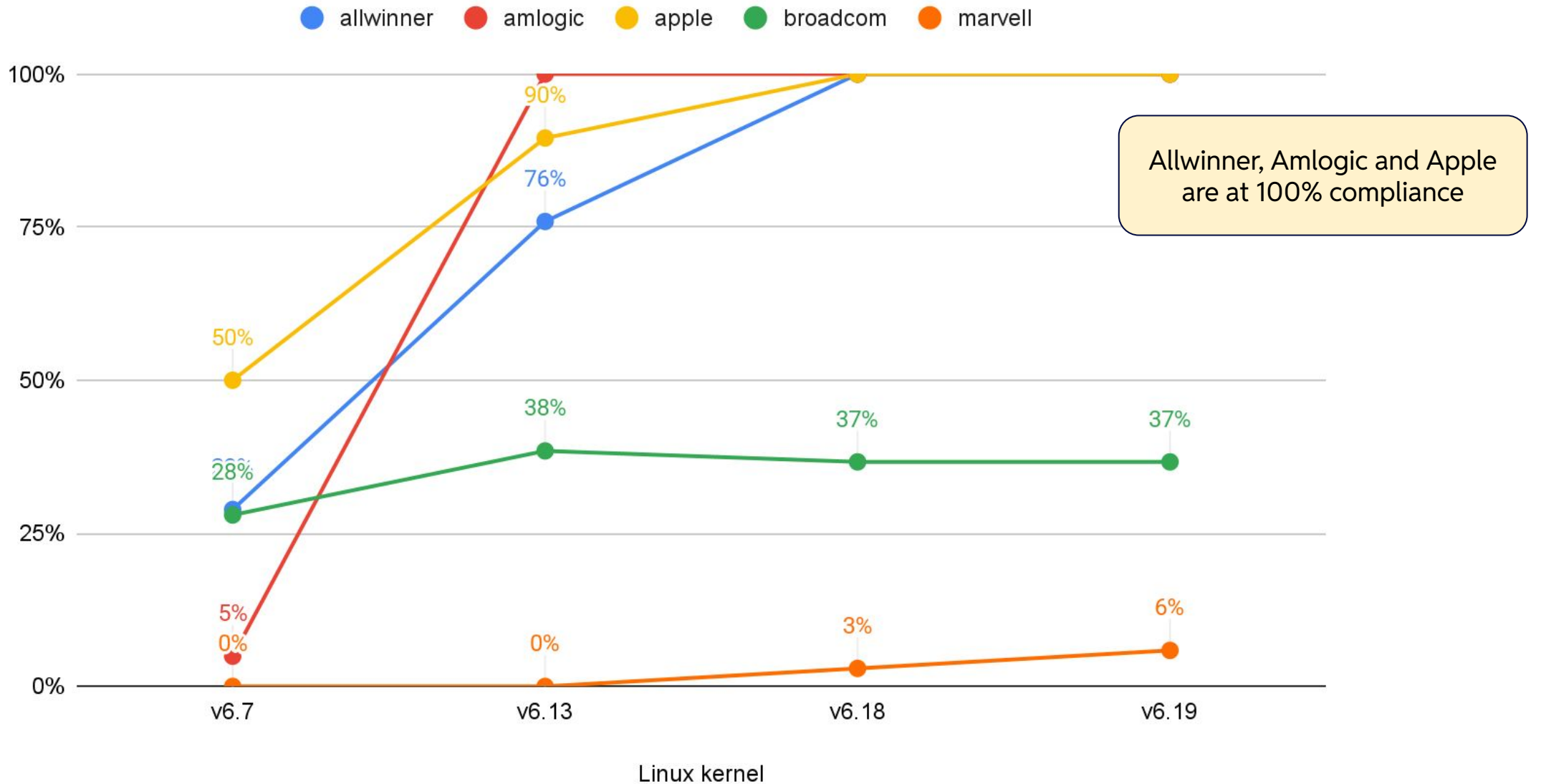
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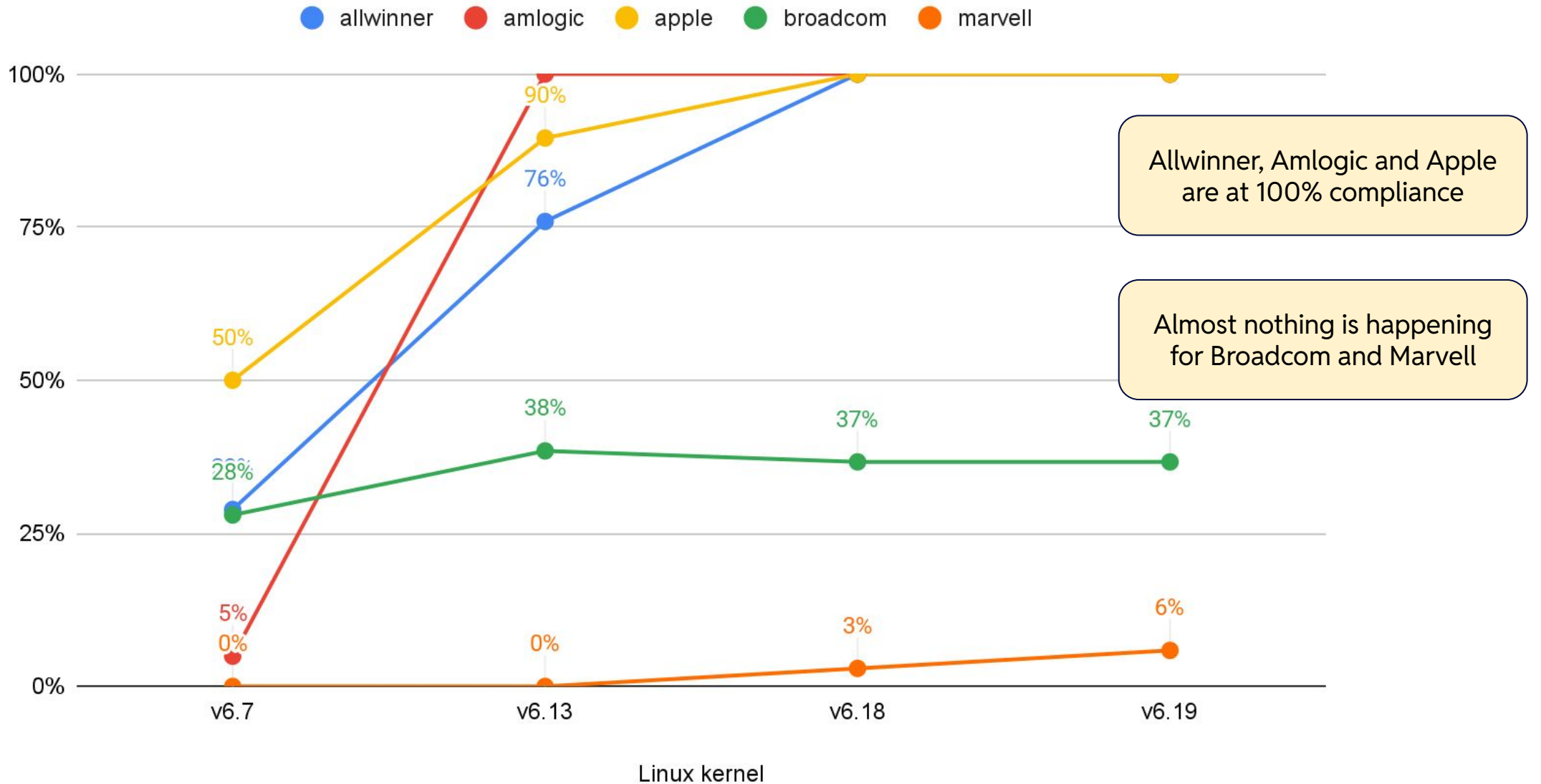
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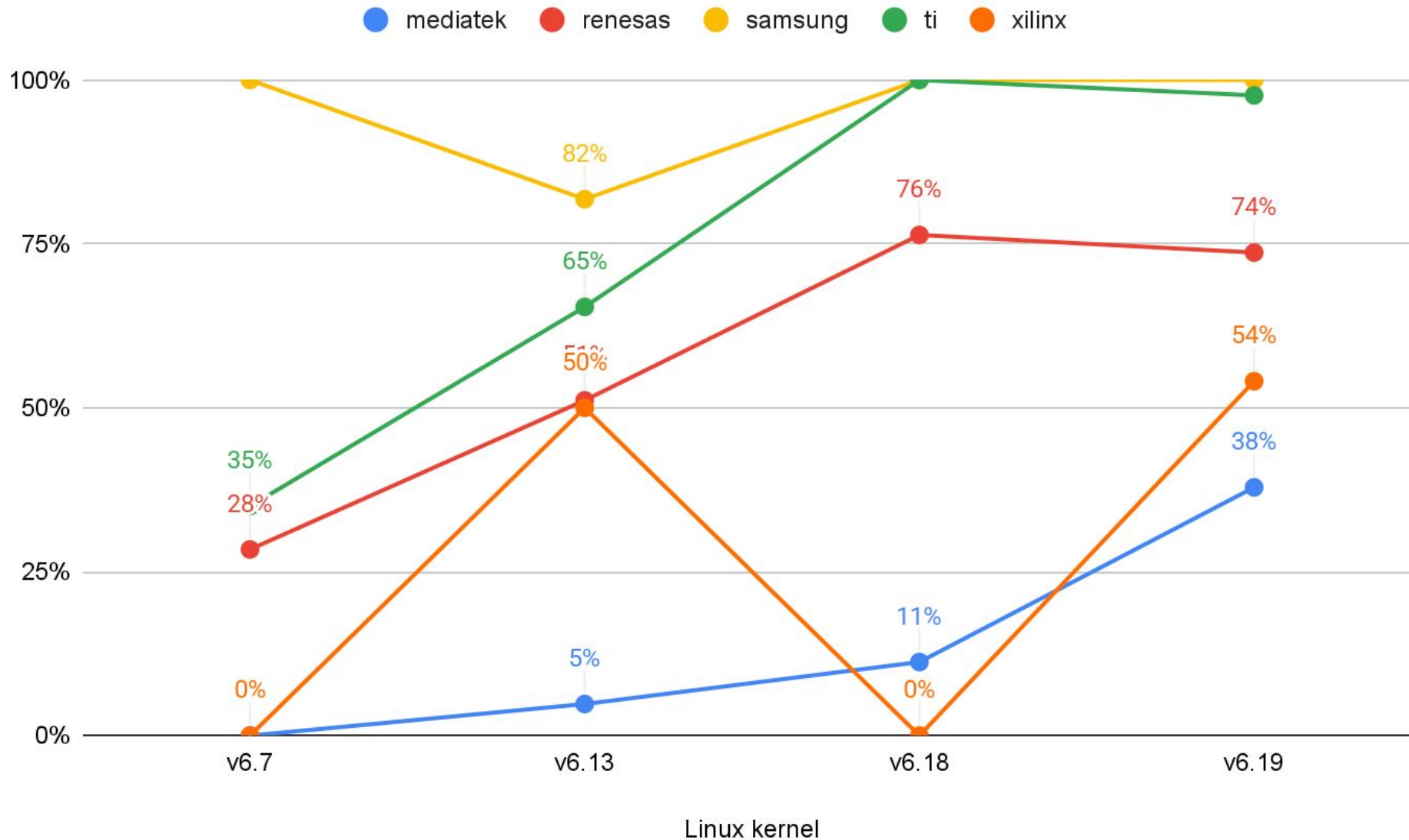


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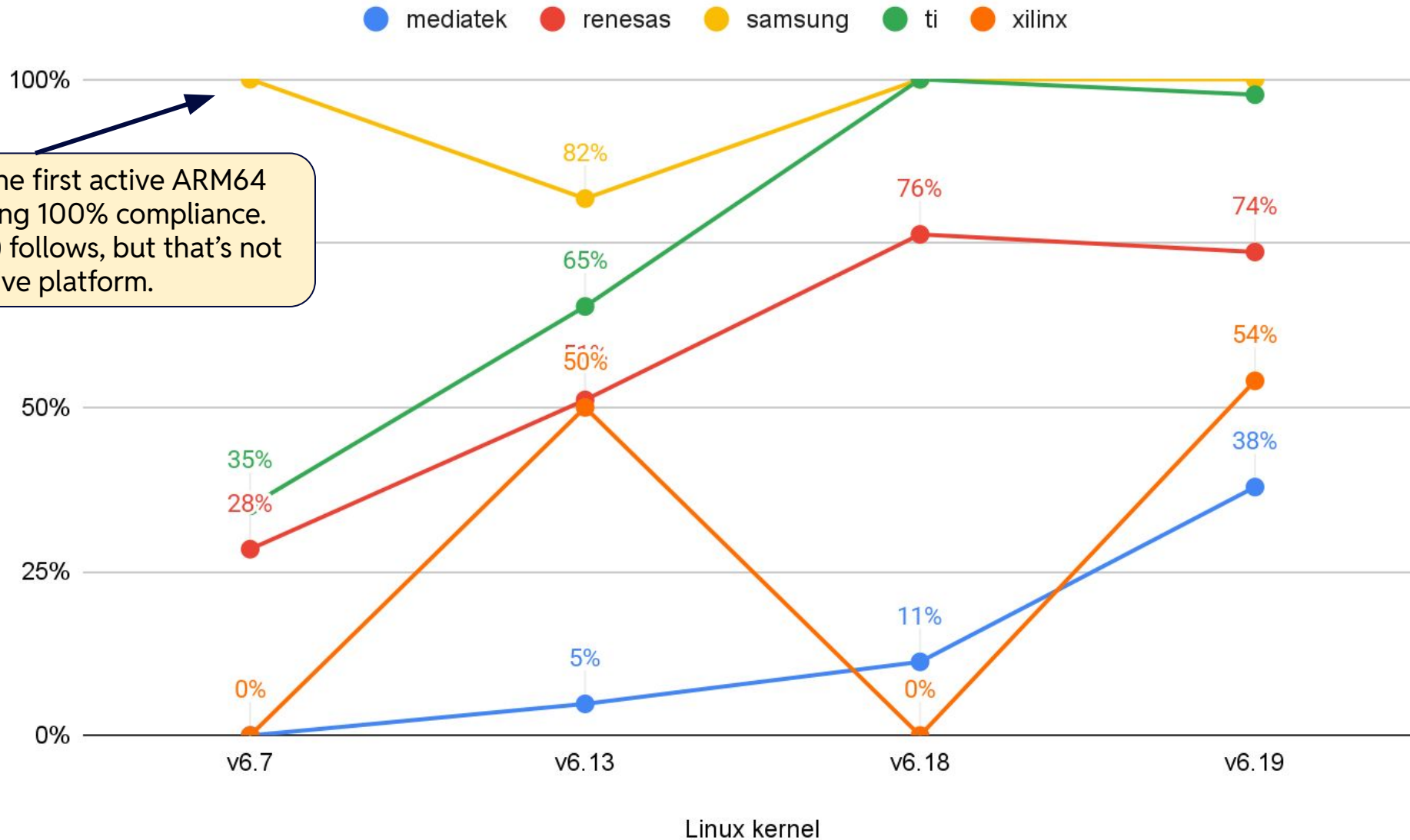




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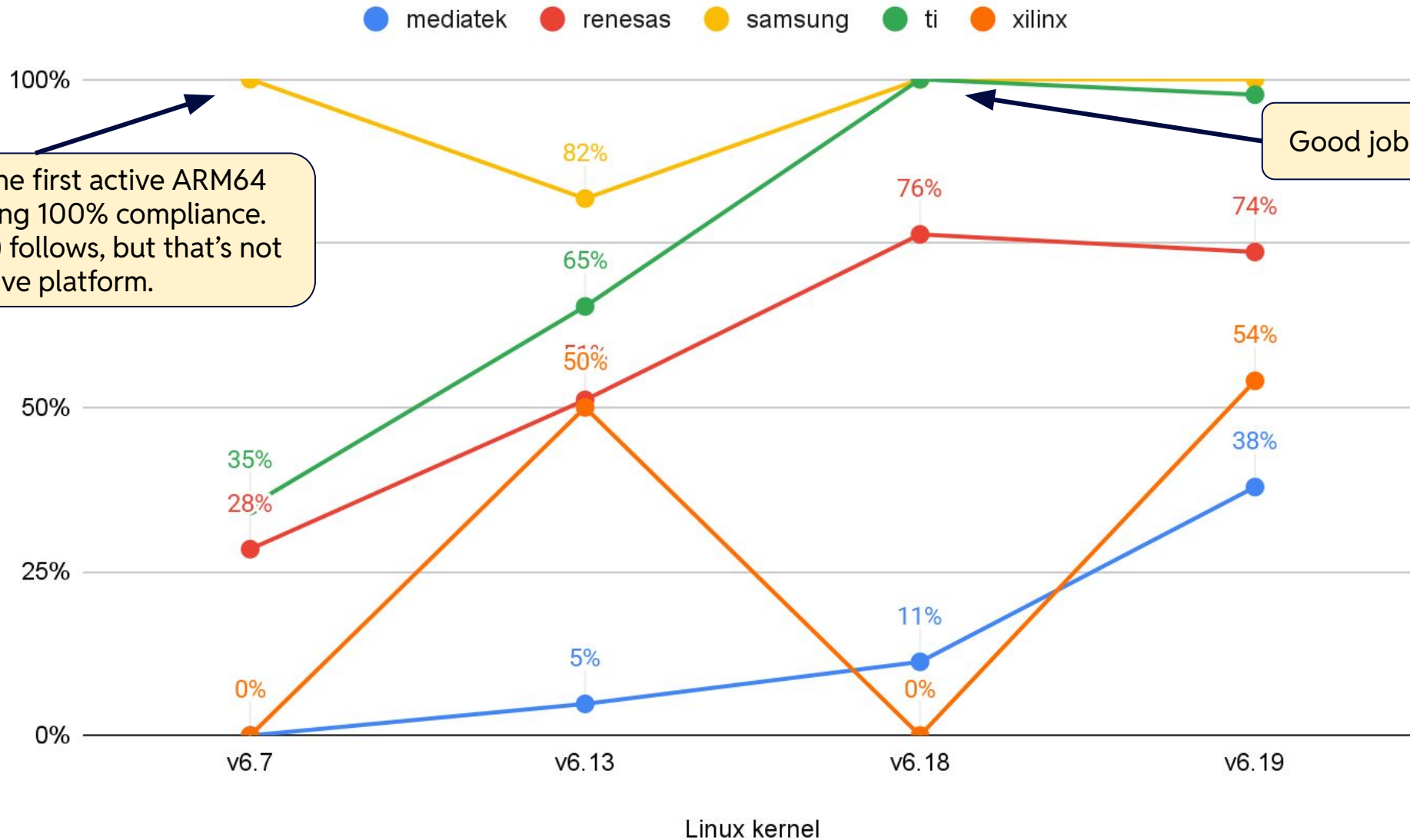


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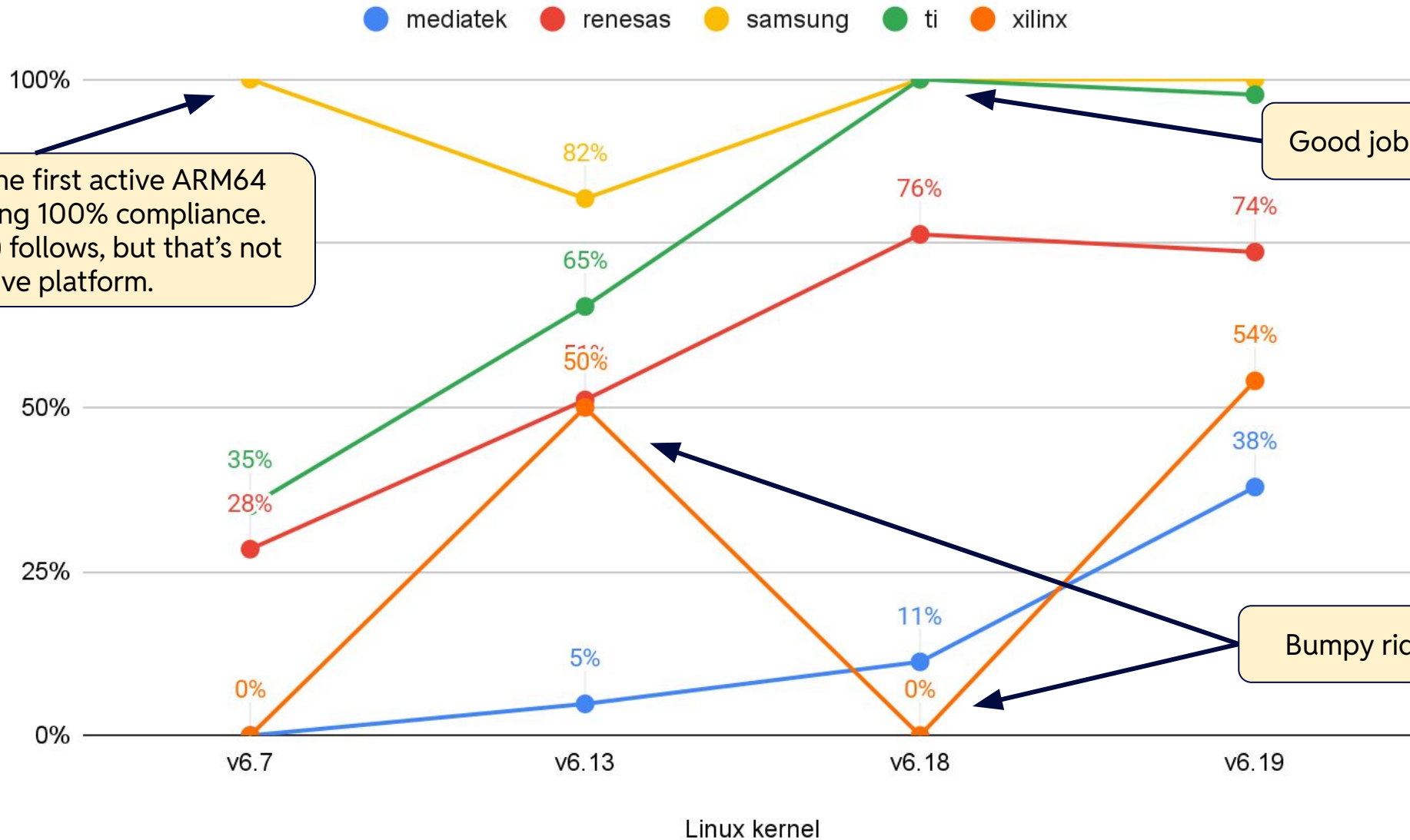


Samsung was the first active ARM64 platform reaching 100% compliance. ST (with 1 target) follows, but that's not an active platform.

# Percentage of Warning-free Targets (Higher Better) - ARM64



# Percentage of Warning-free Targets (Higher Better) - ARM64



## Warning-free Platforms (Higher Better) - ARM64, v6.19 (next)

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets | LoC   |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|-------|
| actions      | 100%                               | 2           | 1007  |
| airoha       | 100%                               | 1           | 509   |
| allwinner    | 100%                               | 61          | 19096 |
| altera       | 100%                               | 3           | 1158  |
| amazon       | 100%                               | 2           | 725   |
| amlogic      | 100%                               | 100         | 37138 |
| apple        | 100%                               | 92          | 26375 |
| axiado       | 100%                               | 1           | 604   |
| blaize       | 100%                               | 1           | 361   |

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets | LoC    |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|--------|
| bst          | 100%                               | 1           | 123    |
| cix          | 100%                               | 1           | 1080   |
| intel        | 100%                               | 9           | 2718   |
| samsung      | 100%                               | 21          | 36021  |
| sophgo       | 100%                               | 1           | 204    |
| synaptics    | 100%                               | 2           | 378    |
| ti           | 97.6%                              | 128         | 69486  |
| freescale    | 97.3%                              | 297         | 155467 |

## Platforms with Only Warnings - ARM64, v6.19 (next)

| SoC Platform | Percentage of Warning-free Targets | No. Targets | LoC   |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-------------|-------|
| apm          | 0%                                 | 2           | 2094  |
| bitmain      | 0%                                 | 1           | 413   |
| cavium       | 0%                                 | 2           | 660   |
| hisilicon    | 0%                                 | 7           | 12743 |
| lg           | 0%                                 | 2           | 478   |
| microchip    | 0%                                 | 5           | 2403  |
| nvidia       | 0%                                 | 20          | 45495 |
| realtek      | 0%                                 | 9           | 1203  |
| socionext    | 0%                                 | 8           | 3580  |
| toshiba      | 0%                                 | 2           | 788   |

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  - Allwinner
  - Amlogic (early, v6.12!)
  - Apple
  - Intel/Altera (at v6.19)
  - NXP/Freescale
  - Texas Instruments

# Summary



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# Thank you

Krzysztof Kozlowski

krzk@kernel.org, [@krzk@social.kernel.org](mailto:@krzk@social.kernel.org)



# Thank you

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